

Six-Sided Disasters

By Ethan Vu

To my mom, my dad, and Uncle Norman



Chapter 1: Snake Eyes

“Honestly, I have no clue how to understand emotions. If I could choose, I would stick with numbers in a heartbeat. Formulas are definitive, measurable, and beautiful, unlike mushy feelings...No no no, of course you are beautiful too! Shh! Let me finish.”

“Ahem—I enjoy physics for the same reason: it allows us to describe everything with certainty. Although I would be lying if I said physics was not mushy either. You know, it's crazy to think that quantum mechanics existed for barely over a century and-”

“Excuse me? I’ll have you know, I have always been a nerd!”

“Anyways, um, all I want to say is that...I am glad. Whether the universe was predestined from the start or the culmination of infinitesimally small uncertainties, I’m glad.”

“I hope someone creates a formula to solve this...irritating, never-ending paradox of life. But, for now, I have one proposed solution.”

“I do.”

High school; the perfect example of trying to merge expectations with stupidity. Because of this, two prominent pieces of human nature are.

First; the need to fit in. Whether it be in a clique, club, or cl...gang, the sense of community protects from the feeling of being alone.

Second; there is the need to stand out, which contradicts the first one. Popularity, strength, fashion, creativity, sports, or for any number of reasons, being unique builds a sense of identity.

Here at the renowned institution of Euler Academy, all the students are no stranger to the pursuit of knowledge. From highly accelerated classes to top-of-the-line tutoring programs, many students attempt to climb the ladder of prestige.

But no such programs can match the level of clout brought by the Centurion Exams. Recognized worldwide, this single six-hour-long test covering all subjects can skyrocket a simple student to stardom. Someone like...

“Seventh...?” he says, gritting his teeth through an eye-twitching grimace. Asher is one of these students, dedicated to the pursuit of recognition.

A huge bulletin board is hung next to the large auditorium building, where hundreds of kids swarm to see the results. Only the top 100 scores are shown, but the names placed in the top three are laminated. Asher didn’t bother inquiring further.

He wipes the dust off his glasses and slowly saunters through the sea of people. *It’s fine...I just need to try harder next time. I still have two more years left; I have time. It’s fine...*

Suddenly, a loud commotion behind Asher quickly forces him to whip his head around. A large circle forms around a singular person.

“Wow, you got a perfect score?!”

“I didn’t know you were a genius!”

“Um, if you don’t mind, would you like to study together at the library?”

Voices in the crowd expressed praise and laughter, as Asher begrudgingly tilted his head up and stared at the board.

A familiar name, laminated in gold, shot needles into Asher’s soul as it sat at the top. *1. Vince Knox - 100.00*

A weight began to swell between Asher’s lungs as he clutched his shirt. Inhaling sharply, he lets out a long sigh. *Not a good way to start the year. Just...don't think about it.*

Second year, first period, day 1. Almost immediately, Asher is hit with a waft of sound, shifting him backwards. *So obnoxiously loud.*

He begins unknowingly frowning, with wrinkles drawing lines across his face. Asher turns over, and almost immediately starts grinning ear-to-ear. *Center column, second row! It has the best field of view for the board and has a good audio range for the entire class. Plus, I can’t be called a teacher’s pet. Absolute perfection!* A small, goofy smirk forms on Asher’s face as he walks to his aforementioned seat.

Completely unaware, Asher barely dodges getting trampled on by a group of classmates. One of which sits on top of his prized desk as the rest surround it.

Aw, seriously? Couldn’t you have picked any other place to huddle around? Asher quietly clicks his tongue as he reluctantly sits down on an adjacent seat. Unpacking his backpack, Asher takes a small glance. *Woah...*

It was a girl, sitting cross-legged on the desk. The top of her dress was white and puffy, adorned with a small bow, and her legs were covered by a long flowing red skirt. But that wasn't what got Asher's attention.

Her hair is pure white, silver almost. I mean, she most likely dyed it, but that seems like a lot of effort for how much hair she has. Wait...her eyes are red too, maybe she didn't dye her hair. What was the term, albino? That's kind of interesting.

Asher pulls out a textbook, leans forward, and begins taking notes. Unfortunately, he can't help but overhear their conversation.

"Did you hear? The Centurion scores got posted today," someone mentions.

"Oh, should we all go and check it out?" another asks. Asher's attention is piqued, subtly tilting his head. *I wonder if she—*

"Why bother? It's an overrated test." The girl on the desk responds, adjusting her hair over her ear. Asher's mental jaw just dropped.

Annnnd I spoke too soon, silly me. Asher turns away, attempting to focus more on his study.

"Really? Nearly everyone at school is talking about it. There was a huge gathering near the auditorium earlier."

"Who cares? It's just a fun activity for normal students to dream about," the girl leans back on the desk, towering over the others, "like gambling!" Asher's pencil halts, with a quiet crunch.

Quietly, Asher begins to repeatedly tap his foot to divert his attention. Alas, it's no use.

"C'mon, you do realize the exams are pointless, right? Only the top scores are recognized by colleges anyway, so everyone wishing to get on the board is more pointless. Besides, everyone with top scores are most likely carried by either their parents or their credit card." The girl smirks.

"You're wrong." Asher quietly responds, just loud enough to get everyone's attention. He keeps his gaze locked onto his textbook as he writes. The smirk fades.

"Who are you, and who asked?" The girl looks down at Asher with a scornful look. Asher doesn't reciprocate a single glance.

"Nobody needs to ask to correct someone," Asher's demeanor runs cold. "You're wrong about the exams. The top

scores have confirmed acceptances, but the rest of the top hundred still have a statistically advantage.”

“Well, you just proved me right, so?” The girl remarks, looking around to gather her support.

“I didn’t. You said they were pointless, remember? If there is some advantage, regardless of what kind, doesn’t that mean there is a *point*?” Asher continues to write. The girl’s ears slowly turn red as her breathing subtly quickens.

“Just ignore him,” someone says.

“Yeah, why bother?” The voices in the neighboring desks begin to clamor. Instead, the girl jumps down from the desk and confronts Asher.

“Well, you think you’re so smart, don’t you?” A light flush covers the girl’s face. “But I bet no one cares, do they? You just defend the dumb exams because you have nothing else to show for yourself. All you “nose-in-a-book” types are all the same.”

Silence, the writing stops. The girl turns around, whipping her hair around as it cascades down her back.

“Tsk, serves you right,” the girl scoffs, looking over her shoulder, “you’re probably by yourself for the same reason.” She hears the commotion from her group and grins.

“Asher.” He finally turns, glaring from the corner of his eye.

“What?” The girl turns back.

“Your first question.” Asher grabs his chair and angles it towards her. He lifts one leg onto the seat, crosses his arms on his knee, and stares at the girl. “Asher.”

The girl stands in the middle of the classroom, stunned. Her face contorts in confusion as she attempts to formulate a response. Before any words are spoken, her friends pull her over and show their phones. After just a few seconds, her and her friends’ eyes are glued to the screen, eyes widen. They all slowly turn, mouths slightly open in disbelief.

“Verne...?” The girl mutters, glancing between the phone and Asher. A zoomed-in photo emanated from the small device, 7. *Asher Verne* - 97.39. The flush on her face grew brighter, and her breathing shallower. She glances around in desperation.

“For future reference, the first rule of any debate is to attack the opponents’ arguments, not the opponents themselves. Attacking your opponent only means you ran out of options.” Asher responds dryly, barely moving from his current position.

The girl staggers back, deeply offended.

“Do you not know who I am?!” Her voice was a level below a yell. “I’ll have you know I—”

“No, and if it doesn’t relate to this situation right now, then it doesn’t matter.” Asher sits up and puts his leg down.

“You...I—” The girl’s demeanor is one step away from exploding. She laughs uneasily. “Y-you know what? It doesn’t matter! I know the person who got first place, so you—”

“They aren’t here, and I’m not talking to them. I’m talking to you, isn’t that right?” Asher leans forward, head resting on his hands.

“Shut up!” The girl clenches her fists as she throws them to her sides, her breathing barely controls her flustered anger. “So what? We’re in the same class, aren’t we?!”

“Ah,” Asher looks down, a small grin begins to form. “Those placed in the accelerated courses are informed weeks in advance, before the Centurion exams are posted. But the extra classes are added after the normal school periods.” Asher slyly looks and tilts his head. “So, how come you don’t know?”

As if a fuse finally reached its keg, smoke rose from the girl’s head. Her face became a tomato, her eyes contracted from anger.

“You don’t know anything! Stupid!” Her volume rose to another level. With almost a pleading look, she glances around the room again.

“Ah ah ah, first rule, remember?” Asher remarked slyly. The girl started hyperventilating, reaching a breaking point. Slightly grinning, Asher braces for anticipated retaliation.

However, instead of a loud encounter, she puffed out her cheeks and pouted.

Asher was briefly stunlock, not anticipating this outcome. He tried to say something afterward, but was immediately prevented. The girl covered her face and stormed to the back of the classroom, followers in tow. Scornful remarks flew Asher’s way.

Coincidentally, the teacher had just walked into the room, seeing how a girl flusteredly scrambled away from Asher. She gave him an intense glare, but proceeded with the class as normal.

Ah, crap. I probably went overboard, again, didn’t I? Now, everyone probably thinks I made a girl cry. Well, she didn’t cry, so maybe it’s not that bad. But, man, what a way to start the year. Asher slouches down in his lap, but then glances

beside him. *Ooo, the seat is free now. Mine!* Asher giggled to himself as he climbed to the middle seat.

A few hours pass. The bell rings. *English was a disaster, though, not because of the English. Or, I guess it was, in a way. Tomorrow, I should clean up my behavior and apologize. Heh, Dad will probably scold me. Not because I argued with someone, but because I argued with a girl. I don't know her name.*

Second period class arrives, Science. The tables are placed in pairs, with a seating chart placed at the front of the room. *That's disappointing, but I guess I don't mind.* Asher doesn't bother reading his partner's name.

He walks to his seat: right column, center row. There, he sees his partner already sitting, hunched over, writing. *Huh, I guess they beat me to it. Seems like these seats are for the entire year, I'll go introduce myself.*

From afar, Asher could only see a green hooded figure, blending in with the table due to their black cargo pants. Asher sits beside them quietly, climbing onto the raised chair. Closer, the hooded figure started to resemble a female silhouette. Curiosity got the better of him, and Asher slowly leaned in for a closer look.

Wait a minute...hold on. Asher couldn't see into the hood, but he did notice a tuft of white jutting out. *That has to be the same girl! It can't be that someone has the exact same hair color as her, right? Fate is a funny thing.* Biting his tongue, Asher prevented himself from escalating anything. However, curiosity had him in its grasp.

Asher looked down at the table, attempting to see what the girl was writing. Lo and behold, a Centurion study packet. Asher's tongue was not sealed for much longer.

"Wow," Asher smuggily remarked right out of the gate, slow clapping and all. "How prideful you were on your high horse, and look at you now. Aren't those for people who are, for lack of a better term, lacking? Such a shame I am not only sitting next to a hypocrite, but a comedian too." Quiet, no response, nothing. Asher expected some sort of backlash, at least small banter, but nothing.

Suddenly, a quiet whimper drilled itself into Asher's ears, his smug face completely vanishing. The hooded figure clutched the Centurion packet and slowly looked up at Asher, breathing unevenly. Her eyes, large and green, started tearing up. It looked like the same girl.

“Wait, I—” Asher tries to quickly reconcile, but it is too late. The girl snatched her things and ran back to the back of the classroom. She sat in the corner, curled herself into a ball, and fully wrapped herself in her hoodie. The teacher stood in front, processing the entire ordeal, while Asher stood there in shock.

“Miss,” the teacher begins, “This class requires you to have a lab partner throughout the entire course. Please return to your seat...” No movement, not a sound. The teacher sighs from exhaustion. “Today is an introduction, so I’ll let this slide for today. Please return to your seat tomorrow.”

Asher turns back around and into the table. Whispers and comments circulate throughout the classroom.

Okay, what the heck just happened? That had to be the same girl...but her eyes are a completely different color. Is that like a fashion thing? Ack, shut up! I am a jerk, stop trying to justify it. I can’t wait to apologize tomorrow; I need to apologize today! Asher begins to tap his feet.

Once the bell rings again, the girl bolts through the door, into the sea of students. Lunchtime rush hour. *Dang it, lost her.*

Speedwalking across campus, Asher scans the entire area. *Okay, she seemed like she had a large group of friends, so I’ll check the cafeteria. Wait, but she seemed timid during science, so maybe the library? Hold on, am I forgetting something, or was her hair shorter? I’m probably overthinking it.*

As fate would have it, Asher saw a patch of white at the corner of his eye. He picked up the pace. *Alright, Asher, here is the plan. Just go up to her and say you’re sorry. Simple enough.*

Approaching the girl seemed like she was wearing another outfit. Yellow polo, black cardigan, white skirt, and white knee-socks. her hair was different, long but wavy, with two ribbons on each side. *But it has to be the same girl, right? How would there be multiple girls with that exact same hair color...it just has to be. Maybe she is just fast at changing, or something. Anyways, I am getting sidetracked, do what I came here to do!*

Getting closer, Asher sees the girl walking and chatting with a group of girls. Smaller than in the morning, but definitely more that second period. Raising his hand slightly,

Asher puts on the friendliest and most unimposing face he can make to get her attention.

Once he got close enough, the girl noticed him. Mid-sentence, the girl stops and glares at him, pestered, almost angrily. Her yellow eyes pierced through his thin mask.

“Hey...could I—” Asher tries to speak

“Don’t even try,” the girl turns away and continues walking, “Loser.”

He is completely stunned, like a deer in headlights. A fuse blows somewhere in Asher’s mind, as he races to find an explanation....nothing.

Asher walks away slowly, defeated. He sits down by a nearby bench and takes out some boxed lunch. *Something is seriously wrong with me.*

Quietly chewing his food, Asher clutches at his chest. A swelling forms again. *I feel terrible. Maybe she’s right.*

Inhaling sharply, Asher grits his teeth. *If I decided not to give up back then, I won’t give up now! if I have to swallow my pride, I’ll apologize!*

Lunch ends, and third period begins. P.E. Asher and the rest of the class dressed in athletic attire and headed to the field. Most conversed, some gossip, but Asher had his eye on a

white ponytail hidden in the front of the alphabetical lineup. *Bingo.*

Asher contemplates at the back of the class. *Maybe I can get her attention during the running portion. It’ll be kind of difficult to catch up; I need to do this. Still, it does suck that I—*

“Hey, Coach?” a hand raised next to the ponytail. Her blue skirt bounced seemingly from enthusiasm. “Can I help with setting up the field?” She gets a thumbs-up and begins running.

“I’ll help too!” Asher blurts, quickly trying to raise his hand. The coach gives a confused expression, but ultimately shoos me away. *Finally, this is my chance!* He runs and attempts to catch up with the girl.

“Hey!” Asher yells, without any response. For how big the field is, the girl got fairly far. Asher begins to sprint. “Hey! C-could we talk?” No response. *Maybe I’m not close enough.*

Asher reaches the storage room, filled with equipment, balls, and an assortment of cones. He hears rummaging from inside.

“Please,” Asher asks, slightly winded, “Slow down, would you—” With no time to react, the girl zips by in the

blink of an eye, carrying a large stack of bright orange cones.

“Ack—C’mon! I need to talk to you!”

First the cones, then the balls, next art supplies...Asher has been running in circles. *Why are we outside of the field? Don't we have class? Ah, heuff—I, can't, run anymore.* Asher wearily collapses.

A loud thud emanates through the school halls, startling the girl to a halt. She turns around, almost skipping towards the drenched corpse.

“Are you okay?” The girl asked, genuinely. He tries to mutter words, but his face is buried into the hard floor, exhausted. The girl leaned over, slowly wafting her tank top.

They make eye contact. Asher, expecting disgust or pity, receives, albeit confused, concern from large blue eyes. Before any words could be exchanged, an unintelligible call returned the girl to running, leaving Asher sad on the floor. His butt is sticking up. *I am so confused...*

Dejected, Asher eventually picks himself up as the bell rings. He slumps to his next period. A haze of both disappointment and self-loathing loops over him as he opens the classroom door.

Fate is a funny mistress, as he, again, sees that familiar shade of white. Sitting. Alone. Not running. Without hesitation, Asher seizes his opportunity.

“You,” He approaches with wavering confidence, “Can we finally talk?” The girl looks up, about to speak. Without warning, Asher puts a hand on his chest and bows. “I understand you have been avoiding me, and for good reason. I was rude and inconsiderate. I let my emotions, not to mention my pride, get the better of me. I want to sincerely apologize for how I have acted, and hopefully reconcile.” Nothing, absolute silence. *Um, why is nothing happening?*

Asher slowly lifts his head, looking around the room. He notices chatter from the bystanding students, but from the whispers, it doesn't seem to be directed at him. Raising his head fully, he sees the girl.

A small, dark leather jacket and light grey shorts. An orange shirt, tied in a small knot. Hair, same shade of silver white, but disheveled and messy, with a large lock sticking out the top. *Delinquent coded...?*

The girl leaned back in her seat, wrapping her hands behind her head. Asher scans the room further. Although she sat in the middle of the classroom, no surrounding desks were

filled. It was as if there was an invisible force field.

“Uh, who are you?” The girl tilted her head, her orange eyes scrunched. Though not because of malice, but of unbridled confusion. The tone was strange too; rather, it expressed, instead, *do you not know who I am?*

There was a long, drawn-out silence, with Asher’s brain completely fried from his numerous encounters. A loud screech resonated from the intercom, breaking the awkward standstill.

“Asher Verne, please report to the dean’s office. Asher Verne, please report to the dean’s office.” The monotone response ended with a click. The rest of the classroom became filled with muffled laughs and comments. *Oh no. I am so in trouble.*

“What number are we on?” the dean asks, sitting at an imposing desk, staring at a stack of paper.

“Seventh, ma’am.” the secretary sternly answers. the dean rubs her eyes in irritation.

“Seriously, this is such a headache. They’re lucky that they’re our main financial contributor—” A knock on the door cuts the dean’s sentence off. “Come in!”

Asher timidly opens the large glass door, slouching with great heaviness.

“Please, make it quick.” Asher solemnly requests, planting himself in a nearby chair. Both the dean and the secretary are taken aback.

“Asher...Verne, right? Is something wrong?” the dean places the paper down and looks over the desk.

“Why else would I be called to the office today of all days except to be reprimanded. Especially since I’m missing my afternoon and advanced classes.” Asher groans, burying his face in his hands. “Just kill me now...” He mutters the last part louder than expected, leading to concerned expressions.

“Well, turn that frown upside down,” the dean exclaims with rehearsed confidence, “Because congratulations, Asher! You have been selected for a rare opportunity!”

“Wait...what?”

“You are familiar with the coveted Centurion Letter of Recommendation, correct?”

“Yeah...who doesn’t?” Asher mutters, still dejected. “It’s given to anyone who ranks in the top three on the exams, pretty much the golden ticket to anywhere. It’s pretty much the reason why the exams are so popular.”

“What if I told you there is a way for you to be awarded one?” A loud slam startled the dean as papers flew across the room. Asher, after a complete 180, is perched on the dean’s desk.

“Really!?!?” Asher’s eyes are filled with a newfound sparkle, his voice dripping with childlike excitement.

“Yes, but I have to warn you, you’ll have to—”

“I’ll do it! I don’t care, I’ll do it!” *I need to be as assertive as possible to make sure I don’t miss this opportunity. At least, I think I am being assertive.* A line of drool forms on the side of Asher’s mouth.

After a long debrief and school ends, Asher finds himself sitting on a bike, staring at a stack of paper on the side of the road.

So I’ve skimmed the document to know that this is a tutoring gig. That doesn’t seem too difficult. But... Asher averts his gaze and stares at the mountainous pass in front of him. *This part is actually going to kill me.*

Sharply inhaling, Asher clutches the bike’s handlebars. *It’ll be worth it! It’ll be worth it! It’ll be worth it!!!*

Sluggishly, Asher climbed, repeating the message in his head. Eventually, the chant became less about encouragement, more about regret. After a treacherous journey, with harrowing wobbles and a chance to lose all of his progress, he finally reached the top.

Salvation! Solid ground! Asher collapsed on a nearby patch of grass shamelessly, exhausted. He stayed in the same position for quite some time, until he gathered enough energy to look up.

In front of him was a huge house, marbled and pristine. The glass windows towered over his height by nearly double, and the bushes were completely geometric. *Of course, the super-rich mansion is in the mountains. It can’t be next to the school, or downtown, it has to be in the mountains.*

Asher finally stands up and dusts himself off. He approached the front door of the building, still tired. Pressing the large doorbell, a long sequence of chimes and ringing made Asher stand in place, awkwardly. He tries to make himself slightly more presentable.

It'll be worth it. The door slowly opens, and Asher's heart sinks deep within his chest. *There is no way...*

Same hair color. Same face. *It's that girl! I was so distracted I completely forgot! This is my penance, isn't it?* She stood in the doorway, unfazed. Her hair is braided, wearing a fluffy purple sweater. She adjusts the round glasses on her face, shielding caramel eyes.

"I..." Asher rubs the back of his neck. "I don't know what to say."

"You must be the new tutor," the girl politely remarks, opening the door further and stepping out of the way. "Please, come in."

As if stepping into a hazardous area, Asher cautiously walks into the home. The walls match the marbled pattern from outside, lining the long hallway. Asher sheepishly trails his new tutee.

"I'm sorry...I don't understand." Asher stops in the middle of the hallway. "I don't enjoy feeling guilty, but you're acting like you don't remember anything that happened today."

The girl giggles softly, covering her mouth with her hand.

"Don't worry," she says, "we get that a lot." Asher's mental gears turn until something pops.

"Excuse me?" Asher completely shuts down. "Did you say 'we'?" Suddenly, chatter from outside the hallway becomes clear.

"You need to practice socializing!" The first girl pulls on another's wrist.

"Yo, who drank all the milk?" The second leaned into the large fridge

"Tsk, you wouldn't catch me drinking that fat juice." The third stared at her phone, adjusting her hair.

"I'm fine...I swear." The fourth had her wrist pulled against her will.

"Can someone check the oven?" The fifth peaking out of the bathroom.

"Hey! Everyone! Our new tutor just got here." The sixth calls out, standing next to Asher as heads turn.

Same hair color, same face. Same color hair, same face. Same color hair, same face. Same color hair, same face...

"Oh *hell* no!"

"Wait, I recognize this kid."

"Me too! I've seen this nerd before."

“Eep~”

“Weird, I think I’ve seen him before.”

“Well, that’s convenient.”

Asher processes his new situation, screaming internally.

For whatever god I have angered, I am deeply sorry.

Because...I am definitely in hell.

Chapter 2: Loaded Dice

“So, h-hi,” Asher uncomfortably chuckles, standing in the middle of the living room, fidgeting with his hands. “My name is Asher...it’s nice to meet...*all*...of you. I will be your new tutor starting today. So, uh, would someone please tell me what the *heck* is going on? Am I tripping? Why are there six of the same person in front of me?”

Across from Asher was an intimidating array of disgruntled faces, splayed over the expensive couch. Anger, indifference, disgust, fear, complete obliviousness; Asher could barely keep the lump in his throat from surfacing.

“Seriously,” The first mutters, purposely loud enough for everyone to hear. “I sometimes question myself why I do so much for the school if *these* are the types of people they employ. They don’t take the time to read thoroughly,” She crosses her legs and covers her mouth as if looking at her fingernails, but gives Asher an unwelcoming stare.

“Sup.” The second mumbles, clearly becoming one with the couch as she sips on a small juice box. Her free hand wraps behind the headrest.

“I know, right?” The third remark, briefly taking her attention away from her phone to give a reassuring nudge. “It’s like, there are only dumb nerds that go to our school.”

“...That’s a contradiction...” The fourth whimpers, hugging her legs while curled up in front of the couch. She gets side-eyed by the third, forcing her to quickly avert her gaze. Accidentally making eye contact with Asher, she makes a quiet squeak and quickly hides her face.

“Uh...” The fifth drone, as if returning from a long daydream. “Oh! Wait, are you our new tutor?” She exclaims loudly. The rest of the girls squint their eyes at her, blissfully unaware. A faint trail of smoke looms in. “Oh crap! My cookies!!!” She bolts out of the living room. There is a brief silence.

“Don’t mind her, she’s like that.” The sixth stands up and places her glasses in a side pocket. “Assuming you didn’t read the information documents...um, how do I put this, we are sextuplets.”

“I’m sorry, *what?*” Asher sputters, dumbfounded

“*Pfft*—you said sex.” The second quietly laughs. The sixth gives a calm, but weary, smile.

“Identical sisters,” the sixth continues, “think of twins, but there are six of us. Neat, huh?”

“Wait...seriously?” Asher’s eyes widen, riddled with curiosity. He swiftly pulls out his phone. “That’s a statistical anomaly, isn’t it? I think I saw somewhere the ratio scales by eighty-nine for each subsequent kid born. So that is eighty-nine to the power of five minus one...” His voice begins to trail off as he is punching in numbers while squinting at his phone. “That’s one out of roughly six million—”

“*AUGH*, can it with the *nerd* speak, four-eyes!” The third places her phone down on the couch and starts advancing towards Asher. “I can’t look at my phone since your yapping is melting my ears.” She tries to intimidate him by getting up in his face, but he’s barely taller than her, so it falls short.

“I suppose that’s a good thing, right?” Asher looks down at her with a blank expression, unfazed. “That means I can do the thing I was paid to do...and the other incentive.” He mumbles the last part.

There is a standstill, as the third girl’s attempts at eliciting a reaction fail. She just irritably stands in front of Asher with an angry grimace, processing his words.

“...Hold on!” Asher exclaims, as if struck by lightning. “If you are all identical...would mean that I didn’t talk to the same—”

“This is ridiculous!” The first girl huffs, stomping loudly as she stands up from the couch. “I can’t believe we are wasting so much time with all these dang tutors. He’s probably just as unprepared and useless as the rest of them!”

“Funny you mention that,” Asher reaches into his back pocket, pulling the original rolled-up document. “I got a premade practice test provided by the school for our first lesson. I didn’t know why there were six copies...but now I know!” He gives a half-hearted laugh.

“No.” The first crosses her arms, turns away, and pouts.

“What? What do you mean, *no*?” Asher asks, waving the stack of paper.

“I mean *no*. I am not doing anything for a stuck-up jerk like *you*.” She intensely glares, still not as intimidating due to the height difference.

“Look, I’m sorry I made you cry, okay? My emotions got the better of me.” Asher apologizes genuinely, bleeding with some underlying irritation. She reels back, appalled.

“Excuse *me*? I did *not* cry!” A familiar red hue begins to form. *Uh, wrong one.*

“Wait a sec,” The second one sits up, slightly intrigued. “If you didn’t know we were related before, do you know the difference now?”

“Uh, probably not,” Asher responds.

“Do you know our names?” She pulls her hand from behind the couch, resting her cheek on her knuckle. Asher takes a second, reaching into the archives of his mind.

“No, actually,” Asher says, both with realization and surprise. He flips through the document. “I skimmed most of it, but I think I saw a place with names.” A sly grin forms on the third girl. She bolts, snatching the document from Asher’s hands. “Whu—hey!”

“I don’t want to do a dumb test either, so let’s make a little deal~” The third girl grins ear to ear, with a smug chortle. “How about you do a test too? You need to know each of our names before the end of today; how does that sound?”

“Uh...okay,” Asher responds, blankly. “What’s your name?” An anticipatory chuckle escapes from the girl’s lips.

“I’m not telling you, stupid. Also, if you don’t, you are fired from being our tutor!” The third girl exclaims. *They can’t*

be serious, right? I didn't do anything yet, and my job is already at risk? Talk about job security.

"You know what, I like that idea." The first girl says, turning from behind. *Is this allowed?*

"I guess," the sixth gives a concerned expression, "it could be a fun way to get to know each other." *Right, fun.*

"Then it's settled!" The third girl snorts, placing her hands to her side in triumph. "No list, no more tutoring!"

A bead of sweat drips from Asher's cheek. *Of course, this job has to have dumb hiccups. It was too good to be true anyway. I wish I weren't so stupid!*

"Her name is Triss, by the way." The second girl lazily points her thumb at the third. An inevitable fit of rage ensues.

"Di—you! How could you! AUGH!" Triss storms out of the living room, with the other girls prepping to leave too.

"Heya! I'm back! The cookies are a little burnt but still pretty good!" The fifth girl returns, lifting a tray of brown to black circles. She carries herself with a large, beaming smile.

"You!" Asher points to the fifth girl with bravado. "Tell me your name."

"My name?" She replies, unaware. "My name is—" She is quickly pulled over by the second girl, who whispers in

her ear. The smile morphs into a playful grin. "A secret!" *Are you serious?*

Roughly half an hour goes by. Asher sits alone on the couch, his forehead touching his hands, which are shaped like a diamond, as he contemplates his life choices.

Knew this was too good to be true. Maybe there is a reason why I was chosen. They said I wasn't their first tutor, so I am probably second-rate. Oh man, the previous tutors were most likely more qualified. This job is harder than the actual Centurion exams. Crap, I should just—

"Did you give up already?" One of the girls popped out of nowhere, forcing Asher to make a startled squeak.

"GAAah, where did you come from?" Asher swiftly leans back. After a little bit of time calming down, he puts his hand to his mouth and starts analyzing. "Okay, you don't seem to be any of the girls that were initially hostile to me, and you weren't the one who greeted me in. I'm pretty sure you were on the couch, so you aren't the one who was baking. Not Triss...but you are the one who revealed that name."

“Yep,” the girl responds dryly, plopping herself on the opposite end of the couch. “Nice work there, Professor.” She sips on her juice box.

“Could you tell me your name?” Asher asks, stoic.

“Nah.” She answers with the same tone of voice.

“That was a fast response.” Asher leans, no longer stoic, in slight disbelief. “Why not? You told me Triss’ name, did you not?”

“Cus’ she’d get mad at me if I did.” The girl has a slight grin, but she has the same dry voice. *I can’t tell, is she being serious right now? Wasn’t Triss already mad? Ah, whatever.*

Asher tries to analyze her further. Her hair is all messy, and her eyes are a familiar orange hue.

“You were the one I apologized to in front of the whole class, weren’t you?” Asher tilts his head. The girl’s eyes slightly widen.

“Wow, that’s surprising.” She responds with another dry remark. “Nice.” *Is she making fun of me, or actually commending me?*

“Could you tell me your name now?” Asher asks.

“Nope.” She sips more of her juice.

“Figured.” Asher returns to his thinking position until something catches his attention. “Hold on. I swear all of your eyes were a light brown color just now. A caramel, maybe. But your eyes are almost a neon orange. What’s up with that?” There was a small break in between her responses.

“I dunno.” She says, again, with the same indeterminate tone. “Also, looking at people’s eyes is kinda creepy, dude.” *Ouch.*

“Not much help, are you?” Asher jokingly teases. He expected a half-witted response, but his words cut deeper than he expected. She stared blankly for a few seconds. Asher scrambles to think of something to say. “Welp, I guess I’ll try my luck with someone else.”

Asher pushes himself off the couch and attempts to scout out the large terrain. Immediately, he notices the same girl trailing behind him, as if attached to him by some invisible rope.

“What are you doing?” Asher asks, suspicious.

“Just watching.” The girl responds, tossing her juice box into a nearby trashbin. She puts her hands in her pockets.

“...Are you going to help me?” Asher asks.

“Nope.” She responds.

“Figured.” Asher sighs.

Asher aimlessly searched around the house, slowly memorizing the layout. *The long hallway at the entrance has a few doors, possibly bedrooms or closets. Directly connected is the living room, with the couch directly to the right once you leave the hallway. There is a large flatscreen perched on a small island table, which sits in front of the large curtains. I am guessing they have a large yard, but I’ll check that out later. Oh, there is the bathroom, too, which is important.*

He checks uncharted territory. *Dang, their kitchen is huge! The oven is taller than me! I’m guessing all those burnt stains are from that one girl. Hmm, I guess there is a patio right outside. Huh.* Traveling deeper into the direction of the kitchen, Asher finds a glass staircase.

He pops his head into the second floor. *More bedrooms and more floors. I’ll check out that stuff later.* Asher jumps back down and returns to the initial hallway.

At the far end, right next to the entrance, the closest door is slightly open with a faint glow fluorescing out. Asher peeks inside, creaking the door a little.

A fairly endearing bedroom, small compared to what Asher expected. To the right sits a large hexagonal-patterned

bed, perched against a white bookshelf, which matched the color of the walls. To the left has, what looks to be, a black yoga mat, and a poster for an old movie. Far into the bedroom lay a large, quaint, wooden desk, filled with numerous drawers and organized cubbies. Another girl sat at the desk, illuminated by the small book lamp as she wrote.

“Perv.” The previous girl says. Asher jumps, startled by the monotone voice in his ear.

“Right...you’re still here. Why are you so close? Shoo.” Asher waves his fingers. *For now, to prevent myself from mixing them up, I’ll mentally refer to them by color.*

“Oh, hey you two.” The girl at the desk puts her pen down and walks towards us at the doorway. She tilts her head, looking at her sister. Braided hair. Purple sweater. “Did you already tell him your name?”

“No.” Surprisingly, Orange responds with a slightly softer tone. Same dryness though.

“That sounds about right.” Purple softly smiles, then turns to Asher. “I think it would be fair for you to get to know me first before I tell you my name. The floor is yours.” She clasps her hands, then places them down to her waist.

Asher takes time to process, to think about his question. Then, something catches his attention.

“Weren’t you wearing glasses earlier?” Asher asks, placing his hand on his chin. “Matter of fact, *your* eye color is different too. That purple hue seems unnatural...”

“Oh, this?” Purple presses her index finger into her eye, which leads Asher to wince in terror. She gives a calm smile, with a small disk sticking to her finger. “They’re just contacts. My sisters and I all have vision problems. Since we also have problems with others recognizing us, we decided to solve two problems with one solution.” She points at Orange’s eyes. “All of us decided to pick our favorite color, which is nice, since ours are all different. Although it’s common for us to get mixed up, so no fault to you.”

Asher takes a moment, then sneers at Orange.

“What did you mean by ‘I don’t know’ earlier?”

Asher’s eyes narrow. Orange just shrugs. “Well, since I got to know you, could I have your name now?” Purple thinks for a little bit.

“Well, you’ve got to know all of us, not just me.” Purple wraps the end of her braid around her finger. “I don’t mind you asking more questions.” Asher looks around the room.

“That thing you were writing earlier, is that a Centurion study guide?” Asher points at the wooden desk behind Purple.

“Oh, yes.” She walks over and grabs the packet from her desk with grace. Looking down in her hands, she laughs a little. “Sorry, I thought it was a little funny. Our last tutor barely taught us anything, just brought these packets and sat on his phone. He’d say, ‘All you need is in those packets, so stop bothering me!’”

“Do you enjoy doing them?” Asher asks.

“Yeah, sometimes. They are pretty informative, but I really only work on them when I have free time at home.” Purple places the packet back onto the desk. *So she wasn’t the one I made cry. That tracks, she said she hasn’t met me before.*

“Um...” Asher scratches the back of his head. “Why do you like the color purple?” She gives a delighted smile.

“Let me think... It’s very calming, and it gives me a soothing sensation. Oh, I heard that purple is rarely found in nature, so maybe I like it because it’s unique!” Purple’s voice is quiet, but this particular question made her sound more endearing.

“That’s pretty cool. I like the color green.” Asher ponders for a bit. “No particular reason, though.”

“Oh, you are just like one of my sisters.” She quietly giggles. “She loves the color green, too.” Purple wraps her hands behind her back and leans forward. “Well, I think it's fair to say you've gotten to know me, so I'll hold my end of the bargain.” She lifts one of her hands. “My name is Heather, it's nice to meet you.” *Finally, reason!*

“Pleasure to meet you, I look forward to working with you.” Asher firmly shakes Heather's hand, firmer than she expected. “Thanks for the chat, I'm going to see if I can talk to your other siblings.” Asher turns to his side. “I assume *you* are coming too?”

“You bet,” Orange says, walking down the hallway. Asher begins to follow suit, but stops halfway, then returns to Heather's doorway.

“If you don't mind, could you help me convince your sisters?” Asher asks, pointing down the hallway with his thumb. Heather pauses midway through her pulling out her chair to sit. She pauses.

“Sure,” Heather says, pushing her chair back in. “Why not?” Asher moves out of the way to let her through, and both of them walk into the living room. Loud, witty snickering could be heard from the couch area.

“My my~” The voice echoed. “I guess you aren't completely dumb after all. At least, for a nerd~” Asher turns the corner; yellow polo, yellow ribbons.

“Doesn't a nerd imply being smart?” Asher coldly remarks. Sputtering for a few seconds, Yellow huffs, then returns to her bold demeanor.

“Who cares? Doesn't matter.” She says, twirling a lock of hair between her fingers. “What does matter is by the end of today, you will be leaving and *never* coming back!” *Why does she sound like a villain from a Disney movie? Dramatic much.*

“We will see about that, won't we,” Asher responds, hiding his grin, “*Triss?*” Triss shoots a few glances at Orange, but returns to her prideful pose. She stands on top of the couch while leaning against the wall. Tilting her head slightly up and crossing her arms, Triss exudes an air of superiority. Finally, she is significantly taller than Asher.

Reaching into her pocket, Triss pops a cookie into her mouth and begins to chew with bluster, as if trying to prove a point. Her eyes narrow with a sly grin, eating the cookie in a rhythmic pace. That pace subtly slows, the superiority fading. Soon, Triss stops chewing, and a concerned expression lingers on her face.

“Hey P~?” Triss yells, sweeter compared to how she spoke with Asher. “Did you burn the cookies?”

“Sorry, just a little bit.” A distant voice echoed from upstairs. “I’m making another batch!” Triss grabs a handkerchief and spits into it, then sighs.

“I told her the ingredients, recipe, and everything,” Triss mutters, shaking her head. She returns to smiling. “Cracks me up sometimes. Anyways~” Triss points at Asher with her palm up. “Just give up already, there’s no point.”

Asher looks at Triss with an unamused expression, then walks towards the staircase.

“So it starts with a ‘P’? Thanks for the tip.” Asher salutes Triss, who rolls her eyes. She falls back down on the couch and scoffs. Triss pops another cookie into her mouth, remembers, then spits it into the handkerchief.

Leading, Asher walks to the base of the stairs. A clamour rustled from above, followed by a loud crash. Asher jumps, pushing his limbs inward as if forming a ball. He looks back up.

“WHAAA—” The girl screams, sending herself down like a human rocket. Asher barely has any time to react before he experiences a head-on collision. Both he and the girl tumble

to the floor. *Ow...I’ve seen some rom-com scenes exactly like this one, but this isn’t how it’s supposed to play out. Not like I wanted it to happen or anything. Agh, I think that’s a vertebra jabbing at my ribs.*

“Pe—” Heather exclaims, but cuts herself off. “Are you two okay?”

“I’m sorry~!” The girl gets up, unaware that she used Asher’s chest as cushion, squishing him more. She bows profusely, mostly towards Heather. “I tripped on something when I was coming down. I am so sorry, again.” She kneels down, looking over Asher with blue, teary eyes. “You aren’t hurt, are you?”

“N-never b-better...” Asher groans, completely winded. Blue reaches her arm out, where Asher attempts to grab it with his limp hand. With a jolt, Blue yanks Asher back on his feet, who remains shellshocked from the whole ordeal.

“Oh my, you should watch where you are going,” Triss taunts, poking the edge of her lips. “Maybe there’s a reason why you wear glasses~.” Asher scratches the top of his head.

“Uh, that was supposed to make fun of me, right?” Asher asks, confused about the comment. “Also, don’t you wear contacts?” Her mouth widens, eyes furrow.

“How did—who told him that?” Triss demands at a higher octave, looking around the room. Heather whistles, innocently turning away. Asher rapidly shakes his head, refocusing.

“Okay, blue girl, I need to...” Asher exclaims before trailing off, spinning around in place. “Huh? Where did she go?” A trail of smoke wisps over again, leading to various gasps of realization. “Now what?”

Asher runs towards the crime scene, with the rest of the girls not far behind. He slides across the kitchen floor, witnessing a haphazard stack of boxes balancing a human person. Blue stretches her entire body with the top oven door swung to the side, barely able to grab the distant tray.

“Almost...got it...” Blue mumbles, sticking her tongue out in concentration. She stands on one foot, miraculously keeping the tower stable, as she meticulously claws for the cookie tray with an oven mitt. “And...Gotcha!”

In a span of a few seconds, Blue lunges forward and grabs the tray with both hands. However, she loses contact with her makeshift stool. With a loud yelp, and as the structure collapses, Blue falls onto the floor, still clenching the metal

tray. This launches bronze medallions straight at Asher, pelting him.

“AH! What the?!” Asher screams, shielding his face. “God! Ah—*mmph!* Hmm?...Mmm.” With his mouth open, a cookie coincidentally lands in Asher’s mouth. Switching from pain to intrigue, Asher chews the cookie with curiosity. “...Is that real vanilla bean?”

“Yep! At least, I think so,” Blue says, smiling on the floor. “My sister is a really good baker, so I wanted to see if I could help out!” She lets out a bubbly laugh as she puts her arms behind her to relax. Some time passes. Blue springs to her feet, with her ponytail standing up. “This place is a mess!”

“Hey, wait—” Asher reaches his hand out to no success. In a flash, she's gone. *Not that I got proof, but I'm pretty sure I know who this girl was.* “Slow down!”

Asher runs after Blue, but is quickly sidestepped as she returns to the kitchen. Always a few steps behind, Asher watches her swiftly scoop up all the flung cookies and returns them to the original tray. With a broom, she sweeps up the leftover crumbs as if a tornado had hit the kitchen. Crashing and clanging then filled the room, as dishes and cooking utensils were thrown into the large kitchen sink.

The remaining girls watched as the Scooby-Doo chase unfolded. Heather has a concerned expression, covering her mouth, while both Triss and Orange snickered in amusement. Asher already began panting and forming a sweat.

“PLEASE! STOP!” Asher yells, resting on his knees.

“Yeah? Did you need something?” Blue asks with an innocent look, as more dishes slam into the sink.

“Y-your name! I need—” Asher pants, trying to catch his breath. “I need t-to talk to you so I can...know...what your name is.”

“Oh!” Blue gasps, as if she had an epiphany. “I told you, it's a secret!” She smiles genuinely

“What?” Asher stares at her, eyes slightly twitching.

“That is not *a* name, let alone *your* name.”

“You don't know, it could be a name!” Blue giggles.

“My sister told me not to tell you my name, so it's a secret!” Asher regains a semblance of physical composure as he turns over to Orange, giving him another equanimous shrug.

“Well, you see, I spoke with your *other* sister,” Asher says, fed up, using the tone of voice fit for arguing with a child. “And Heather told me her name after I got to know her. Do you think I could do the same with you?”

“Why do you want to know my name so much? Is this like a game!?” Blue squeals, jumping up and down. “Why didn't anyone tell me?” In the distance, Triss rolls her eyes. “Well, mister tutor, I like cooking, cleaning, baking...” *Evidently.* “...Running, swimming, hiking...I guess I like eating and sleeping too! I like—”

“Okay, okay, I think I got it. You *like* a lot of things, don't you?” Asher asks with a worn-down expression.

“Ahah! Sorry, I was rambling.” Blue continues to smile, rubbing the back of her head in embarrassment. “How about you ask me something and I'll answer instead?” Covering his eyes, Asher reels back and sharply inhales. He sighs.

“Why did you use the top oven instead of the one below it?” Asher asks, returning to his stoic voice. Blue begins fidgeting with the bottom of her skirt.

“Ah, well...so you know how, uh...” She looks away, trying to come up with an excuse.

“She blew up something in the oven a few days ago.” Orange's voice calls from a distance. Asher's eyes widen in fear.

“How did you manage to do that?!” Asher slowly steps back. The girl's smile starts to dim.

“Heheh, just...” Blue’s voice slowly trails. “How about I tell you my name, and you don’t ask, hmm?” Asher squints with curiosity, then sighs.

“You got yourself a deal.” Asher reaches his hand out. “The name’s Asher.”

“Great!” Blue snatches his hand and begins rapidly shaking my hand. “My name is Petra!” The handshake goes on longer than expected, faster almost, as Asher starts to get worried.

Suddenly, Asher jumps from a strange sensation in his feet. Looking down, he notices a long stream of water creeping from the bathroom. Looking up, Petra’s gone.

“Oops! I left the shower on!” Petra’s voice echoes from down the hall. The rest of the girls laugh while Asher is silent, stunned.

*What the heck is going on? What am I doing here? This is so much chaos for a darn letter. They don’t want me here anyway, so why am I jumping through hoops like I’m some sort of clown? If only I had scored better on the test, I wouldn’t be—*Asher gets tapped on the shoulder, sending him out of his daze.

“GAH! What? What’s happening?” Asher gasps, startled. He hears a soft giggle beside him.

“Don’t mind Petra, she’s silly like that.” Heather points her head towards the stairs. “The eldest sister is probably upstairs. I can show you her room.”

“Oldest? I thought you were all identical...” Asher asks, then quickly has a realization. “Wait, no, technically... never mind. That would be helpful, thank you.” He walks behind Heather, then notices the other two following.

“So you’ve been tagging along this whole time, that makes sense,” Asher observes, then points at Triss. “But why are *you* following?”

“To see this happen.” Triss slyly smiles, then pops one of the new cookies in her mouth. “Duh.” She reacts with content about the taste.

Asher climbs up the stairs, staring down. *Alright, I got...three names already. At this rate, I could have my first lesson by tonight! I don’t know what’s more stressful, studying or this. At least it’s a change of pace...I got this.*

Chapter 3: Second Chances

“No.” The girl pouts, peaking through the crack in the bedroom door. “Absolutely not! I’m not going to talk to him, let alone let him in my room!” She tries slamming the door, but the sound is underwhelming.

“Oh, don’t be like that,” Heather says, putting her hands on her hips like a disappointed mother. “This is not how you treat a guest.”

“Guest? How is an unwelcome, inconsiderate stranger a guest?” The voice, muffled, punched through the walls. “Not to mention tacky!” *Ouch, uncalled for.* The other two girls giggle behind Asher.

“Strangers or not, he’ll be helping us with our studies.” Heather politely pushes the door. “Let’s all settle down and have a discussion—” The door slams shut again, forcing Heather to stumble backward.

“Really?!” Heather’s volume increases, not as loud compared to her sisters, but louder than usual. “You are acting like a little girl; how do you think Mother and Father would respond? Please, open the door.” She pushes harder on the door and is met with an equal, opposing force.

“Don’t bring our parents into this!” She and Heather begin a tug-of-war, both giving no ground. “Neither of them is here and won’t be here for a while, and you know that! Plus, you stop acting like Mom!” Asher stands behind Heather, witnessing as an innocent bystander.

“Uh...I appreciate the effort, but you don’t need to go through all the trouble,” Asher defuses, with Heather standing back from the door. “I mean, this activity is really a formality, if you think about it. If I am to be a good tutor, I should get to know the people I’m tutoring. It’s only fair.” Asher gives a half-hearted shrug with a laid-back smile. “Besides, you can’t fire me on a whim, so if this is how you want to be, so be it.”

“He doesn’t know, does he?” Triss smirks, leaning against the opposite wall.

“Huh? Is there something I should know?” Asher’s eyebrows scrunch, confused.

“That girl in there has direct connections with Euler’s top folks. If she wants you gone, you’ll be fired before you leave the house!” Triss laughs, with a cheesy, villain-of-the-week type of laugh. Regardless, Asher grows paranoid.

“You’re joking, right?” Asher’s smile has a slight tremor. Although Triss turns away as if she’s clueless, Heather gives him a silent nod. “Ha.” Asher rams himself into the bedroom door. “Open the door, young lady!”

“Never, creep!” The girl inside bites back with venom.

“How about we, you know, talk? Like civilized human beings?” Asher pushes on the door as hard as he can, readjusting his feet as he loses traction.

“Yeah, trying to barge into a girl’s room is so civilized!” She yells.

“Now you listen here! I am coming in there, and we are going to get to know each other like adults!” Asher tries pushing at different heights.

“Excuse me? Why do *you* sound like my Dad?!” Only

“Damn, why are you so strong?” Asher mutters to himself. After a minute or so, Asher concedes, tending to his hands.

“That’s kinda embarrassing.” A familiar dry voice pokes at Asher’s broken state. The girl yawns, stretching her arms behind her head.

“First of all, this expensive house is super slippery, so I can barely get any footing. Secondly...” Asher continues to

ramble, closing his eyes and counting on his fingers. During his preoccupied complaining, she cracked every bone in her neck and fingers, then rubbed her hands together. “And also, she most definitely has better leverage than I do! I have to push, while she could just be sitting on the—”

Without breaking a sweat, she swings the bedroom door wide open, with the girl inside sliding across the floor. She smacks her hands together like a proud construction worker.

“Traitor.” The girl inside mumbles, crossing her arms and pouting. Heather walks inside and wraps her arms around her sister, where Asher slowly scans the room.

Her’s is slightly bigger than Heather’s, nearly double. Dang, she has an entire floating shelf that circles the entire room. Oboe, martial arts, tennis, speech and debate...that’s a lot of trophies. Wait, really? Her wall has a giant picture of her portrait. Talk about pretentious.

The room lacked a speck of dust anywhere. The rightmost part of the room had a large mirror, which covered the entrance to a closet. To the left, another study table filled with books and a half-open laptop. Finally, in the middle of the room sat the largest bed Asher had ever seen, with a pink

canopy and drapes. The girl smothered her face in her blanket as she sat on the bedside, with Heather rubbing her back.

“Wow, what a pleasant room!” Asher exclaims, acting all excited.

“Stop trying to act all chummy.” The girl says, her voice muffled by the blanket. “You’re not supposed to be here.”

“You got so many awards! That’s so cool, which one is your favorite?” Asher continues as if he heard nothing, his tone having the personality of plastic.

“Can you stop talking!” The girl jumps up and growls. A reddish hue grows on her face. “All of these stupid tutors are just useless!”

“Hey, don’t be like that,” Heather says calmly, resting on her sister’s shoulder. “Out of all of them, Asher seems to be putting in the most effort.” *Well, I wouldn’t have to if I weren’t forced to do Hercules’ Twelve Labors.* “I think it’s best for us to try and get along.”

“Why do you care so much?” The sister tries to push Heather off to no avail. “He’s another run-of-the-mill, cookie-cutter, pretentious brat.” Harsh. Also, look whose

talking? “If I can request a replacement, why should I waste my time?”

“Well…” Heather plays with her sister’s hair. “Look where that has gotten us? We haven’t had someone stay for that long, and our second year just started.

“Yeah, but…” The sister’s voice softened

“No buts, we need to start acting differently if we are to have change.” Heather smiles. The sister pouts, not in anger, but in discomfort. “In any case, removing everyone you dislike isn’t a good habit for a president.”

Tick. Tick. DING! A proverbial lightbulb goes off in Asher’s brain as he scrambles to pull out his phone.

“Hmm? What are you doing?” Heather tilts her head just before her sister returns to her angry demeanor. She had a similar lightbulb go off in her brain, slightly delayed.

“You have to be kidding me, Heather!” She yells as Heather tries to figure out what she did wrong. “You just gave him the answer on a silver platter! My name is on the school website for crying out loud!”

She clenches her fist and raises it behind her head, as if she is about to throw a tantrum. Closing her eyes and puffing

her cheeks, she looks like she is about to explode. The sister huffs in frustration.

“I wish I never agreed to this stupid wager. Just look at him!” Asher continues to type on his phone, pretending not listen. “Another idiotic groupie who only cares about whatever Dad did!” She turns to Heather. “Honestly, I can’t believe you sometimes. You need to stop being inconsiderate and start thinking before you say something!”

Asher stops typing and glances up. Heather stares at the floor and somberly trudges towards the door. The sister’s breaths are shallow, but she has a twinge in her eye, as if deliberating with herself.

“Wait.” Asher’s voice goes cold. He places his phone in his pocket and crosses his arms. Heather stops in the doorway, with her sister making a puzzled look. “You are right. The whole point of this exercise was to get to know you all. It wouldn’t be fair to take a shortcut.”

The sister opens her mouth to say something, but no words come out, as if she is quietly being choked. She closes her mouth and grimaces.

“I don’t know who your father is,” Asher continues. “It was you who pointed out how I didn’t read the document

carefully, wasn’t it? I have my reasons for taking this job, that’s true, too.” Asher puts one hand on his side and slightly tilts his head up. “But if it’ll help, I’ll prove to you that I’m not a stuck-up jerk.”

The sister glances at Asher, then at Heather, then back to Asher. After some back and forth, she loosens her grip and sighs. The red in her face begins to settle down.

“Fine…” The sister says, reluctantly, with her body turned away. “I guess…” Heather regains some light in her eyes as she smiles widely. She gives double thumbs up before slowly closing the door behind us.

An uncomfortable amount of time passes before the sister glares at Asher from the corner of her eye. This makes Asher jump, losing his stoic composure.

“So, uh…” Asher thinks, trying to break the awkward silence. “Why do you like the color red?”

“It’s a color, what of it?” She glares harder. *Okay, tense.*

“Right. Cool. How about my first question, which of those trophies do you like the most?” Asher gulps.

“None of them. All of them are worthless to me.” She speaks with a sharp tongue. *Seriously, this is like talking to a wall with wet paint! Hold on, is that how the saying goes?*

“Heheh, cool.” Asher begins to sweat. “You mentioned something about your Dad, right? What does he—”

“Monette.” She cuts off Asher.

“...Huh?” He asks, confused.

“Listen here.” The sister turns towards him, her expression emanating the same frustration. “This does not mean we are friends, got that? I...” She looks away. “I’m only doing this because I feel bad for my sister...And if I am to stay as a respectable school president, I have to respect your actions...Not like searching my name would mean anything.”

“Yep, absolutely!” Asher smiles. She rolls her eyes.

“I’m a person of my word, you got that?” The sister pokes his chest, forcing him to stumble back. “If you don’t complete what my sister told you to do, you’re out, understood?” Asher gives a childish nod, which she doesn’t take too kindly. “You have until eight, no later.” She takes strands of her hair and rolls them between her fingers, then looks away. “My name is Monette. Now get out!”

Asher is shoved out of her bedroom. The door slams, with the correct amount of ‘whelm’. He takes a moment, sitting on the floor, to process the entire situation.

Man, I’m running through so many hurdles today, and didn’t teach anything. Is this what a 9-5 feels like? Asher checks his phone and slowly sighs. An hour left? Really putting me through the wringer, but I guess that’s better than nothing. At least today wasn’t completely unproductive, since I at least spoke to all of them. Maybe, Laplace isn’t a pipe dream after all... He closes his eyes, leaning against the wall.

His rest is instantly interrupted as he jolts back up. Asher starts whispering to himself, counting on his fingers. *Wait a second...* Asher walks downstairs to see four of the girls scattered around the living room. One is munching on cookies, another is staring at her phone, and the last two are chatting on the couch. *Crap...I forgot who’s who.*

“Hey, quick question, you said there were six of you, correct?” Asher asks, throwing ‘you’ towards the general audience.

“Uh, yeah.” The one on the phone looks up Asher midway through climbing down the stairs. “What are you, stupid?”

“...I don’t see how not knowing that makes me stupid.” Asher reaches ground level. He places his hand on his chin and

squints. “Judging by how you insulted me unprovoked, you must be...Triss.” She raises an eyebrow.

“Okay, now you’re *really* stupid.” Triss rolls her eyes and continues scrolling on her phone. All of a sudden, Asher hears incomprehensible, muffled speech coming from the kitchen.

“Sorry, what did you say?” Asher leans slightly back to dodge the flying cookie particles. The girl swallows and walks towards him.

“I was trying to say ‘Uh-huh, there are six of us!’” She rubs the crumbs off her face, then tilts her head. “Why do you ask?”

“So...” Asher scratches his face. “I think I only remember speaking to five. I’m not sure about that.”

“Ohhh,” The sister giggles, as if thinking of a funny joke. “I know who you’re talking about. She’s most definitely in her room right now.”

“That’s good to know. Thank you...uh...” Asher trails off and narrows his eyes. “You have to be either Petra or Heather...” She gives an amused laugh.

“You are funny, mister!” She wipes a tear from her eye, then playfully shakes Asher’s hand. “Petra, nice to meet you again!” Asher pulls away, his ears slightly red.

“Stop it, don’t patronize me,” Asher mumbles, somewhat embarrassed. “I assume you had your entire life to distinguish each other, but I had less than a day. Cut me some slack.” Petra laughs, holding her head up with one hand.

“You sound like my oldest sister, Mone—” Petra quickly covers her mouth. “Oops, did I reveal too much?”

“Monette?” Asher asks, unamused. All the girls show slight surprise.

“Wow! You must be such a suave guy!” Petra gives Asher heavy pats on the back.

“I said stop it...and what does suave mean?” Asher mumbles, exasperated. A soft giggle startles Asher, making him turn around.

“I’ll show you her room.” The girl has a polite smile. “Don’t worry, you’ll get used to the identical sisters thing. Maybe.”

“...You must be Heather,” Asher deliberates. She nods as she begins to lead Asher.

Opposite to the direction of the entrance is a continuation of the hallway. No lights were on, keeping the entire area barely visible. Heather stops midway, then points to the door at the end.

“Her room’s right there.” Heather throws her braid over her shoulder. Asher starts approaching, but Heather puts her hand out in front of her. “One thing. For her sake, please don’t open the door this time.”

“Loud and clear.” Asher nods. Heather begins to leave, then it’s Asher who stops her, putting his hand on her shoulder. “One thing too. I know...I barely know any of you. But...” He returns his hand, placing it on his neck. “I assume your sister has trouble apologizing, but I think she feels bad about what she said.” Heather takes on a thoughtful look, then tilts her head.

“Which sister?” She asks, seemingly genuinely.

“What the—you know, the one...she uhhh...why are you asking me that?” Asher sputters, trying to hide the fact that he forgot. Heather gains a cunning smile.

“Good luck.” She winks, then returns to the living room.

Walking to the end of the hallway and standing in the dark, Asher stares at the supposed door. He checks his phone again. *Fifty-five minutes left. It’s fine, this should be easy. Here goes nothing.*

“Hello!” Asher is trying to sound his friendliest. “This is Asher! I saw you on the couch earlier,” *at least I think*, “so I wanted to get to—” He hears cluttered rustling and crashing inside. “...know you...Pretty sure you heard already, but I’m trying to get you and your sisters. For the most part, we’ve compromised that I should get to know each of you first. So...that includes you.”

Asher awkwardly waits for a response.

“Hey, hey, no worries! I am completely fine starting our conversation. After all, I am the tutor!” Asher says cheerfully. “How about this, uh, what do you like to do for fun?”

Again, after a decent amount of time passes, nothing happens. *I know someone is there, so what gives? She’s probably ignoring me, isn’t she? Geez, so close to completion to only fail would be...* Asher checks his phone again. *Devastating.*

“Hey...so, it’s been about thirty minutes. Not to be rude, but I am a little strapped for time. Would it be possible if we could speed this up?”

“Look, you have to work with me. I am this close, and I really need this job, okay?” Asher loses his composure. “All you need to do is tell me your name, and I’ll leave. That’s fair, right?” Continued silence. The glow from his phone only emphasized the twitch in his eye. “Seriously?”

In an act of desperation, Asher lunged at the doorknob. Right when he was about to turn it, he reeled his hand back, as if he had touched a hot pan.

“I seriously do not understand! Just say *something!*” Asher exhales in frustration. He leans, then slides down the wall until he sits down next to the gap under the door. Asher plants his face on his knees.

What is wrong with these girls! It's one thing after another; I can't catch a single break. Geez, this job is so frustrating, and I bet dealing with other people's feelings wasn't in the description. So stupid!

Asher grits his teeth, looking up at the ceiling. His eyes darted across the ceiling, hoping to find a hint of an answer. The materials on top of the room differed from the rest, with a

large wooden beam supporting the white background. His gaze travelled across, analyzing the patterns found in the wood grain.

Asher eventually gets lost in thought, quietly laughing to himself as he sees funny patterns. Eventually, his frustration dissipates.

Well, it's not like I'm completely innocent. I did make one of them super mad, and I made another...cry. Asher sits up. Process of elimination; it can't be the one in the morning, not during lunch, nor PE, nor History...not including the classes I missed today, all that's left is...Science.

Asher turns around and faces the door. *It has to be her, no doubt about it. It makes a lot more sense why I shouldn't open her room. Out of all of them, I'm guessing she is the most sensitive. Then again, I was just being insensitive. Looking back, if I was right, there was no purpose.* Asher gains a regretful look.

I had to run my stupid mouth again. No one else to blame but myself. He quietly chuckles. *No wonder I bombed that exam. now, I bombed the only opportunity to fix it.* Asher sighs, then sharply inhales.

“I’m sorry,” Asher says, his voice lowering. “It’s getting dark, and I think...I think I had a *long* day today...” Quiet. “You were the one I made cry earlier, right?” Nothing. “I know you haven’t said anything yet, but I’ll take that as a yes. Knowing you have identical sisters now, I doubt what I said was for you.” Silence, not the sound of a breath.

“But...” Asher bites his tongue. “I shouldn’t have said any of those things. I got mad, mad at myself mostly, then I got mad at whoever was nearby. I promise it won’t happen again.” He hears a faint rustle, then a thud.

“I completely understand if you don’t want to talk to me. I guess I wouldn’t want to talk to myself at this point.” Asher scratches the back of his head. “I was being genuine about my question, though. I would like to know what you do for fun.”

Some time passes, and Asher gives up. But, unexpectedly, he feels a poking at his legs. Asher stands up, looks down, and then sees a small corner of a sheet of paper. Using his pinky, he slides the rest of the paper out of the door.

The paper has a well-illustrated drawing of a wilted, white flower. Although the style looks nearly lifelike, the petals have distinct geometric shaping, each shaded with a different

color. On the bottom, the stem sprouts from concrete, sending cracks across its floor.

“Q-Qu...My n-name...” A barely audible whimper manages to go through the door. “Q-Queenie.” Asher gains a huge, goofy smile. He then starts coughing profusely.

“Thank you.” Asher smiles. “Truly, for both.” Suddenly, he hears commotion from the living room, a mix of yelling, complaining, and cheering. “I’m guessing your sisters are grouping up together, probably something to do with me.” More silence. “Don’t force yourself. Sorry, and thank you again.”

As if trapped in a cave, Asher’s eyes adjust to the bright light. Similar to earlier, five identical sisters sit in an array on the couch.

“Welcome back.”

“Sure took long.”

“Hey.”

“Could we get this over with?”

“Eeee, I can’t believe you made it!”

Asher’s eyes squint with confusion, but also because the room was very bright.

“What? How is that hard to believe?” Asher scratches his head.

“Not you, silly!” She points behind Asher. “Hi, Sis!” She waves.

He looks around in confusion, then flinches when he turns around. His eyes were still dilated, but he recognized the green hoodie. The girl was slightly hunched over, holding a sketchbook under her arm. Her body language was closed, tightly together like a turtle. *Ah, that’s a relief.* The sister briefly glanced up at Asher, got startled, then timidly sat on the couch.

“Glad to see everyone’s all here!” Asher rubs his eyes. “I suppose we can get started and...” His vision returns to normal, but he rubs his eyes again. “Why are all your eyes the same color?” One of the sisters flinches and slowly pulls out a small plastic box from her pocket. Another places her hand and calmly shakes her head.

“Uh, duh, it's getting late?” One stares at her phone. “You think we would keep our contacts when we go to sleep? That would have them slide behind our eye and—”

“She’s lying.” Another has a slight grin. “She told us to take them off. To make it harder for you.” She gets a silent glare.

“Please, let's finish this dumb activity.” Another sister sternly says. The last sister just smiles. *Are you serious? I had it like a second ago. It's uncanny how alike they look. I guess I'll figure that out later. For now...*

Asher closes his eyes and dramatically raises one hand.

“We got Triss,” Asher announces, raising a finger with flair. One of the sisters rolls their eyes. “Heather, Petra, Monette, and Queenie!” He confidently smiles, posing for an uncomfortable amount of time. A few seconds go by, and his smile drops. He counts his fingers, then counts the sisters on the couch. Petrified, his heart sinks, and his blood runs cold.

“HA!” One of them stands up and points. “Our *tutor* couldn’t learn a few names? That’s *so* embarrassing!” Asher crouches down, pulling on his hair. *All that work...for nothing? Nothing! Oh man, what the heck was I thinking? What am I doing? I wasted my time and embarrassed myself for nothing!* “You should see the look on your face! Seriously, what makes you think you could be *our* tutor if you can’t—”

“Oh yeah, my name’s Diane.” The sister in the middle raises her hand with a placid expression. The rest of the sisters’ jaws drop, turning in complete shock and awe. A tiny, surprised smile forms on Asher’s face as he stands back up. He stands like a superhero, resting both his hands on his side.

“*You* of all people? To him? Really?” The sister who’s standing asks, utterly dumbfounded. She turns back to Asher. “Hey! We aren’t done yet! You can’t tell us apart!” He opens his mouth and raises his hand to rebut, but eventually clenches his fist. Asher places his hand on his chin as his eyes bulge. He scans around the room, back and forth, and draws a blank. Asher starts sweating.

“That’s enough, Triss.” Another sister stands up and places her hand on Triss’ shoulder. “The original deal was for him to list out all our names, not match them. It’s only fair that we honor it.” Triss huffs, sitting back on the couch, as Asher wipes the bead from his forehead.”

“Phew! I really worried for a second there!” Asher closes his eyes and rubs the back of his neck, smiling. “I owe you one, Heather.” Asher chuckles. Silences. Curiously, he slowly opens his eyes.

“Are you kidding me!?” The same sister, fuming.

“I uh—” Asher whimpers. *Oops.*

“I defend you for one second, and this is the thanks I get?! How clueless can you be?!” The red hue becomes more prominent.

“Okay, you must be Monette then, from all the incessant yelling!” Asher bites back.

“*That’s* how you recognize me? I can’t *believe* you!” She puffs out her cheeks.

“Oh, I’m sorry, you all look *identical*. Cut me some slack.”

“Hey, um...I don’t...think we should be, uh, fighting.” A quiet voice tries to break through the yelling, to no effect. Queenie decides to continue sitting in silence.

“That is such an excuse. We are wearing different clothes, how is that so difficult!” Monette approaches Asher.

“How would that help me in any possible way? I just met you all today, clothes barely make a difference! Besides, that’s not what I should be focusing on, is it?” Asher approaches in turn, leading to both of them staring each other down.

“The whole point of clothes is to look at them. What the heck is so difficult for you to understand?” Monette growls.

“Oh, is that true?” Asher asks, mockingly. “If that’s the case, why don’t I just, I don’t know, focus on...freaking chesticles from now on?!” Asher leans down, dramatically widening his eyes as if he were looking at a painting.

“Pfft—chesticles is *crazy*!” Diane bursts into tears, laughing.

I am seriously out of my element here. Honestly, I wouldn’t be able to tell the difference between an A cup or a C cup, or whatever. What I can say...is that I can C A cup, if you know what I’m saying.

“YOU’RE DEAD!” Monette charges with a feral look in her eye.

“Now, now, I know you two get along *so* well.” Heather wraps her arms around Monette, who is actively attempting to claw at Asher.

“Yeah, you wouldn’t want to hurt our tutor on his first day!” Petra smiles, leading Asher to safety. “Wait, they don’t get along, right?”

Once tensions died down and apologies were made, Asher eventually prepped himself to leave. He began to walk down the hallway before turning around.

“Cya, mister tutor!” Petra yells, waving both her hands.

“Bye...” Queenie pulls her hoodie down, waving it close to her chest.

“Sorry about the strange first day,” Heather whispers, passing Asher and closing the door to her bedroom.

“Don’t die!” Diane yells from the couch.

“This is stupid...” Triss mumbles, walking away.

“Augh...” Monette groans, crossing her arms and turning away. “You better do your job the next time you’re here, or I’ll promptly remove you. Got it?” Asher smiles and waves goodbye.

Once outside, Asher can’t help but notice the dusk sunlight bleeding through the clouds. He inhales, taking in all the fresh air. *What a day. What a start to the year, actually. I think I need a nap after what happened, because this felt like a wild dream. Wait...what did one of the sisters tell me?*

Asher blinks, seeing his bike lying on its side, then looks down the mountainous path. He wishes he were in a dream.

It’ll be worth it! It’ll b-be worth it! It’ll be—oh crap, OH MY GOD! WHAAAA—

Chapter 4: The Beginning of Something New

Aside from a few scratches and bruises, Asher is brimming with enthusiasm. Striding down the bustling school hallways, he acts giddy, quietly chuckling at the stack of papers in his hand. Compared to the previous day, he is reinvigorated with excitement.

Passing the auditorium, Asher's glow ripples under another's. Taking a quick glance, he notices a familiar group surrounding the billboard, with the same person standing in the middle. Asher ponders for a second, then grins contentedly. He continues walking.

"Greetings, Monette!" Asher skips into class. "Lovely morning...today..." His voice ultimately drowned out. Similar to yesterday, Monette sits on a desk at the back of the classroom. She radiates confidence as she speaks, with many students surrounding her.

So that's our school president? I suppose that makes sense why she gets the Vince treatment. I doubt she'd want to talk to me anyway. Asher turns and sits down in his seat. *Oh yeah!*

Eventually, the science period arrives. Asher glances at the front and approaches his assigned seat. Surprised, he notices the other seat is filled.

"Queenie? Hey!" Asher places his bag down and sits beside her. "I'm glad you came back. Sorry...about yesterday...again." She lay on the table, face down. Her arms covered her face, with her hoodie being the only thing of recognition.

"...It's fine..." Queenie mumbles, made more difficult by her hoodie. *Yeah, I figured she wasn't the conversational type. I'll leave her alone, too.*

Lunch, and Asher sits alone on an unassuming bench outside, eating a sandwich while taking notes from his textbook. While throwing away his trash, he glances across the courtyard to see a patch of white in a small group of other girls.

That's probably Triss, based on how...stylish she and the other girls look. Kind of surprising, I'd assume all the 'tuplets would eat together, but I guess not...I wonder where the others are anyway. Ah whatever.

P.E. also had a similar feeling. After all the students changed and headed to the gym, Asher tried to approach Petra. Without a single moment to waste, she raised her hand and

sprinted away. *That kind of sucks. I didn't get to say hi. Oh well, I'm not doing that again.*

Fourth period rolls around, History, and again, Asher witnesses a similar sight to yesterday. With the number of seats in the classroom, the center was avoided like the plague. Only one was filled; white hair, staring out the window.

"Mind if I sit here?" No response, not a head shake. Asher sits down anyway. "So...about yesterday. I'm shocked I didn't get your name earlier, but I guess that's the nature of identical siblings, right?" Asher chuckles to lighten the mood. No response. He clears his throat. "Anyways, I just wanted to say thank you, Diane."

Suddenly, after a collective gasp from all the students, the room goes silent. Diane turns around and stares at Asher. *Anger? Disgust? Hatred? I can't tell!* Without any commotion, Diane walks out of the classroom. *Uhhh, what the heck did I do?* She never returns to class.

Without another debrief, Asher visits the fifth period, Math. Although he wants to analyze the previous situation, Asher can't help but smile. Breaking his original rule, Asher aims for a front row seat. His pursuit immediately halts as he sees a familiar hair color.

"Hey, uh...crap, I'll get better at this eventually. Which one are you?" Asher tries to salvage his botched greeting. The girl briefly looks away from her phone, slightly confused.

"Triss..." She answers with a distrustful look. "What are you doing in this class? Shouldn't you be in, like, a smart kid class?"

"I thought I told you I—" *Wait, no, wrong one.* "Sorry, those classes happen after normal classes. I wasn't here the first time because I was called to the office." Asher internally sighs in relief. Triss returns to scrolling on her phone. "Are your friends not in this class?"

"You stalking me?" Triss' pitch skyrockets. "Creep!"

"No, I..." *I don't know what exactly counts as stalking, but I think I saw her at lunch, so maybe.*

"I'm just waiting for them to show up," Triss says, her voice quieter than normal. "That's all."

"I see," Asher says, his voice also quieter than normal. "If you don't mind my asking, do you know what Heather's elective period is?"

"No? Why would I know anything about that?" Triss asks.

“Oh, I just assumed you knew because sisters, and all that stuff.” Awkward silence ensues. She places the screen on her table. “So...what do you do for fun—”

“Okay, stop,” Triss demands. “We aren’t friends, and you aren’t forced to get to know me.” *Why do I feel like I’ve heard this before?* “Now leave me alone.” Slightly unwilling, Asher eventually walks to the front of the class.

“Yo, Aurea, can we talk?” An unfamiliar voice piqued Asher’s curiosity. Turning around, he sees a few boys standing around Triss’ desk. *Aurea? Is that a nickname? Oh, maybe that’s her last name. I feel like I’ve heard it before...*

“Oh, hey~!” Triss puts on a large smile. *She seems popular, maybe that’s a friend or something? Ah, stop it! I shouldn’t be getting in her business, and I’ve been called a creep. Just drop it.*

Asher sits down in a front seat, placing his textbook on his desk. A few seconds later, a bag is thrown on the seat next to him, with Triss not far behind.

“What? I thought you wanted me to leave you alone?” Asher looks up, confused.

“Shut it.” She plants herself on the seat next to him. “Don’t get the wrong idea. Also, why are you sitting in the front? Are you a teacher’s pet?” *Damn, I was caught fast.*

Asher raises his pointer finger and inhales, about to speak.

“Our last name is Aurea. I don’t know who they were.” Triss cuts him off before he can say anything. Asher inhales again. “Talk to me again and I will break your fingers.”

“Ta da! I have returned bearing gifts.” Asher hums a fanfare, dropping a stack of paper on the island table. A bead of sweat rolls down his face.

“...Uh...what is it?” Petra curiously leans over the stack of paper.

“The real question is, why are *you* back?” Monette crosses her arms, sitting at the edge of the couch. “Shouldn’t you have something better to do?”

“I did say I had some practice tests. It’ll help me gauge what you all need help with.” Asher narrows his eyes. “Weren’t *you* the one who told me to do my job?”

“I think she’s asking why you are here today.” Heather comforts her pouting sister. “You aren’t forced to come here every day, are you?”

“Isn’t it obvious?” Triss snickers, scrolling her phone. “He has nothing else better to do. I bet he doesn’t have any friends, too.” Contemplating for a few seconds, Asher brushes off the comment.

“Well, the first step to being a good tutor is trust. Based on yesterday and how you spoke about the previous tutors, I thought it would be a good idea to put my best foot forward.” Asher lifts a small black bin next to his feet. “That also starts with all of you, too. If you’d be so kind, please—”

“OH MY GOD!” Triss screams.

“Ah! What? What happened?” Asher asks, briefly startled.

“Can you believe this!?” Triss pulls Petra back down onto the couch, then shows the rest of her sisters her phone. Slowly creeping behind them, Asher catches a small glimpse. *What was the point of yelling? It’s just a picture of a guy. Not an impressive guy at that. He’s just, sort of good looking, and muscular...and...* Asher snatches Triss’ phone. “Hey!?!”

“I was going to ask for your phones.” Asher places the colorful, tactile phone into the bin. “Thank you for setting an example, *Triss*.”

“Are you kidding me right now? Give it back!” Triss yells. As she tries to jump for the bin, Asher lifts it about his head.

“What’s the big deal anyway? Is he your boyfriend or something?” Asher asks sarcastically. Instantly, Triss’ irritation fade, and her expression goes blank. The atmosphere becomes thick as Triss sits back down. Heather immediately goes to comfort her.

“Not to be bearer of bad news but...” Petra pulls Asher to the side and whispers in his ear. “That would be her ex-boyfriend...” *Great, I put my foot in my mouth once again. Maybe it’s not that bad; she could be over him.* From the corner of his eye, he notices a single tear fall down Triss’ cheek. *Not over it, not over it! Quick, uh, change the subject!*

“Haha, let’s start, shall we?” Asher’s worried grin flickers as beads of sweat drop like bullets. He briefly scans the couch. “I noticed there are only four of you here. That would mean...” He crinkles the ridges on his forehead. “Queenie

and...Diane are missing...?” Asher’s pitch rises when he says the two names.

“Nice job, mister tutor!” Petra springs back up and provides unsolicited headpats, which are quickly swatted away. “I guess you learned a lot from yesterday!” Asher’s eyes narrow.

“Shouldn’t *I* be saying that?” Asher mutters under his breath. Her smile slightly falters.

“H-hey, I could run and grab them for you!” Petra exclaims, hopping up and down as she runs in place. Asher places his hand on her shoulder.

“It’s fine. I’ll do it,” Asher says. Silently nodding, Petra slowly walks back to the couch, with her smile vanishing. *Did I...say something wrong?* “Thanks for asking, though. I appreciate it.”

Although dimmer, Petra grins as she sits back down. Beside her, Monette scoffs.

“Just start the darn thing already.” Monette rests her face on her knuckle, looking away, as she waves her leather-cased phone at Asher. “We’re tested individually anyway, so I’d rather not waste anymore time than *you* already have.”

“Oh, princess~!” Asher snickers in a childish, condescending tone. “I’ll ‘do my job’ and ‘leave you alone’ at the same time, don’t worry your pretty little head!”

“Why you—!” Before Monette has a chance to react, Asher whips around and grabs her phone. Dramatically lifting it over his head, he then softly places it into the bin. With one final spin, Asher grabs a test and offers it to Monette.

“It’ll take about a week to grade all of them, so you’ll get your wish. Anything else...m’lady?” Asher asks, wearing a patronizing grin. She immediately snatches the stack of paper and stands, glaring at Asher for a few seconds.

“Prick.” She mutters, quietly walking up to her room. A silent sigh of relief expelled from Asher’s mind.

He turns back to the couch. Returning to the first issue, he takes a moment to assess the solemn-looking girl. Without flare, he quietly offers a test.

“Um...sorry...?” Asher scratches the back of his head, unsure how to proceed with his current situation. She narrows her eyes at him, then at the test, then back at him. A brief moment passes.

“I don’t care, stupid!” Triss sticks her tongue at him, followed by grabbing the test and storming away. *Well, at least*

she's back to how she originally was...I'm not sure if that's an improvement or not.

Asher hears a plunk from his bin. Slightly turning, he jolts back from a girl's face way too close to him.

"Heheh, test please!" Petra giggles, holding her hand out as if she were receiving food. Trying to keep a serious expression, Asher breaks into a small grin.

"Don't eat it, 'kay?" Asher quietly snickers, handing her a test. Petra tilts her head in confusion, but returns to smiling once.

"Aye aye, sir!" Petra salutes, respecting her drill instructor, then skips away. *That leaves one left, three in total.*

Again, Asher turns back to the couch, holding out the bin and a test. Up another phone and down another test, she quietly stands up and walks to her room.

"Wait, Heather," Asher calls. "Before you go, could you tell me where Diane's room is?" A short amount of time passes, and there is no response. She turns, her cheeks puffed. "W-wait, what? I thought Monette already—or you already left with...I swear, I'm not trying to—"

"Ha, gotcha." Her face returns to a calm demeanor, giggling behind her hand.

"Ah—seriously?! Don't do that! It's hard enough as it is." Asher grits his teeth, with his ears flushing red.

"Oh, I'm sorry." Heather apologizes with a sly smile. "Diane's room is downstairs, right off the bathroom." She points. "I'll get to work now, good luck."

As Heather waves goodbye, Asher is left alone in the living room. *I have to deal with the remaining two. Comparing how she was yesterday, I think I should deal with Diane last.*

The same dark hallway radiates a sense of calm in the quiet ambiance. Asher reaches Queenie's room, noticing a small opening relative to last time. Ruminating, he tries to come up with a plan of attack.

I came across pretty rude last time, and I'm not necessarily crunched for time. However, I don't want to utilize too much time here, especially since I have another sister I have to deal with. Maybe I can try knocking on her door...But I don't want to scare her away. She seems to be the most skittish of the six, like a deer or something. Maybe I could just quietly try to get her attention...but waiting without any response is irritating too! Agh, why am I overthinking this? It's just a door. All I need to do is—.

“Um...” A quiet voice makes Asher jump back. Without him noticing, a head peeked through the crack.

“Oh my—how long have you been standing there?!” Asher shrieks, dumbfounded. Queenie’s eyes grow wide in fear, twinkling under the dim light. She steps back and pulls at the hem of her hood. “Ack, crap, sorry. Didn’t mean to startle you.”

“It’s fine,” Queenie whispers. “And...uh...not very...long.” *She’s probably lying.*

“Well, uh,” Asher quietly says, rattling the phone bin in his hand. “You weren’t on the couch earlier, so I’ll keep this brief. I’m giving you all a practice test, and I need your phone. Do you mind?”

With a subtle nod, she closes the door. Immediately, this is followed by a rattle, a bang, and a crash. *Is there a biohazard in there?* A few seconds later, Asher feels a tap on his foot. Looking down, he sees a clear phone case jutting out of the crack under the door.

So much work just to keep her room a mystery. Whatever, as long as I do my job. Reaching down and grabbing the phone, Asher replaces it with a test halfway through the door. Once it disappears, he becomes aware.

“If not me, give the test to one of your sisters once you finish,” Asher says, standing in the middle of the hallway. After some time, he sighs. *No response. Figured. I hope she heard me.*

Asher steps out into the bright light, shading his eyes. *One remaining. This is going surprisingly smoothly, at least compared to yesterday. So, near the bathroom...*

The kitchen side of the house has two familiar-designed doors, nearly featureless with a sheen of white. Stepping over a pile of damp towels, Asher is again met with another closed bedroom.

Judging by how she acted at school, I probably said something that pissed her off. It kind of tracks, seeing how most of the other sisters reacted to me. But...what did I say? All I did was greet her; at least I didn’t berate her as I did with Monette. Anyways, focus, Asher. This should be a simple task of getting a phone and giving some pieces of paper. This is supposed to be simple...why do I feel this isn’t that simple? I hate how I don’t understand what I did wrong!

Asher clenches his fists together, putting them up to his face as he frustratingly grins at the door. Keeping this up for a

few seconds, he drops his hands and gives an exasperated sigh. Asher knocks on the door.

“Hey, Diane, you there?” Asher asks. As if hit with a sense of déjà vu, there is no response. He rubs his eyes. *Alright...nope, I don't have the patience. Haha, screw it!* Asher reaches for the doorknob. Once turning and opening the door slightly, he feels a tap on his shoulder.

“Whoa. Again? Perv behavior.” Diane dryly says. Asher jumps back in fear.

“GAH! Where did you come from!?” Asher inhales, regaining his composure. “Also, could you stop calling me that?”

“Nothing to be ashamed of, Professor. Wait, no, it is.” Diane languidly leans back, grabbing one arm by the shoulder and stretching the other. “So, you gonna stand there, or are you going to let me inside?”

“Oh, right, sorry.” Asher moves out of the way, allowing Diane to open her bedroom door. *Other than being called a pervert, this is still going smoothly...wait a minute!* “Hold on, why are you talking to me so casually? I thought I made you mad or something, right?”

“Uh, it’s nothing. We’re cool.” Diane nonchalantly responds, stopping halfway from opening the door.

“Are you sure? I saw you leave in the middle of class, distraught,” *or at least that's the best way I can put it.* “Plus, I heard some commotion from some of the other students, so it wasn’t *nothing*.”

There is a drawn-out pause. Diane stares at the door, her hand resting on the doorknob. Asher notices the large lock on her head begins to droop. She glances down, then spins around, lazily putting her hand out toward Asher.

“Aren’t you supposed to give me something?” Diane asks, putting her other hand on her hip while tilting her head.

“What are you talking about—oh right...Hey! Don’t change the subject! What did I do!?” Asher raises his voice, pointing an open palm at her.

“Lay off, will ya?” Diane yawns. “You’re overthinking it.” She beckons with her fingers. *I...maybe she's right.*

“Well, if you were present, you’d know I need something from you first,” Asher smirks.

“Huh?” Diane slightly lifts an eyebrow. “What are you talking about?”

“Exactly, I need your phone,” Asher says, lifting the bin up. Suddenly, he notices a slight change in weight. Asher looks down at the black bin he is holding. There, he sees a sixth phone, a slick black case with a chipped corner. “Wait...what? When did you...how did you know about that? Wait, how did you know I was giving you a test in the first place?”

“Hmm? I dunno.” Diane shrugs. “Now, can I take my test or not?” *The heck do you mean! You don’t know? You clearly know something! She’s doing this on purpose, isn’t she?*

“I’m home,” Asher yells, closing the wooden door behind him. He drops a stack of paper on a nearby drawer as he adjusts his backpack.

“Hey!” A loud masculine voice booms across the house. “Look who decided to show up. You didn’t get beaten up again, did you?”

“Ha ha, very funny, Dad.” Asher rolls his eyes, taking off his shoes. “I told you already, I fell off my bike because that stupid hill is so steep.”

“Whaaaaaat?” Asher’s Dad sarcastically asks. “What are you doing on a hill so late?”

“You serious?” Asher asks, struggling to take off his shoe as he hops on one foot. “I told you, I got a job tutoring a couple of rich girls, and they live on a freaking mountain. It’s almost as if you need a limo to get up there.” His dad laughs in the distance.

“You got beaten up by a couple of girls? Not very becoming of you,” Asher’s Dad chuckles.

“Really, Dad?” Asher finally pops his shoe off and grabs the stack of paper.

“At least it’s better than making love with the floor!” Asher’s Dad yells.

“What does that even—” Asher cuts himself off. “Oh...I don’t like you, Dad.”

“Love you, too. Dinner will be done soon, so get ready to eat!” Asher’s Dad says.

Asher walks into a small living room. *Huh, I mean our couch isn’t that small. But, just comparing the two isn’t a competition. Our TV, too. I think that mansion is getting to me.* While not paying attention, Asher is briefly startled by a force lower abdomen.

“Welcome home~!” A tiny child quietly says, hugging Asher’s legs. A black head of hair with a small, fluffy, red jacket emanated cuteness. He places a hand on her head, ruffling her hair.

“Hey, Callie.” Asher smiles. “Did you do your homework yet?”

“Yup!” Callie looks up and smiles brighter. “I did alllllll my homework. I made a collage!” She lifts up a sheet of printer paper, plastered with an assortment of images and text. *The theme seemed to be early Halloween, judging from the dark motif and the large, toothy grin.*

“Wow, so spooky!” Asher playfully says. A blank expression spreads on Callie’s face, briefly silent.

“It’s supposed to be happy,” Callie says, her dark brown eyes widening.

“Ah...” Asher mirrors the blank expression. “I see.” He looks around, trying to change the subject. “Is Mom home yet?”

“Nope.” Callie smiles. *I would normally expect more context, but she’s so cute.*

“Get ready for dinner, okay? I’ll be down in a little bit.” Asher provides more headpats.

“Oke~!” Callie runs away, her arms and hair spring up and down each time she steps. Asher shortly follows, then changes directions to walk up the stairs.

Again, I am hit with the sense of comparison. I wouldn’t be surprised if they have another floor. Though from what I saw, it’s still a lot larger than just a handful of rooms. I’m not...I don’t think I’m jealous. Wait, why am I thinking about this so much?

Asher reaches the top, walking towards a pair of rooms. One is pitch black, with the door open. The other has a crack open, with light creeping across the floor.

“Hey, Percy, dinner will be ready soon,” Asher says, opening the lit door slightly. Inside, a minimalistic layout, consisting of just a bed and a desk setup, with a built-in closet out of view.

“Alright. Thanks.” A quiet, cold voice responds. Percy, Asher’s older brother, turns his head around while sitting in his chair. Familiar black hair and brown eyes, Percy wears a thick black jacket and a blue scarf, which covers his mouth and nose. He turns back around.

More conversation would be nice, but it’s fine. I suppose you can act however you want once you become a

Centurion scholar. Although there isn't much fanfare as I would have expected.

Asher turns on the light in the other room. A very similar layout, but cubicles are completely filled with junk and scrap paper, with clothes scattered across the floor. He pushes some out of the way with his feet. Asher tosses the stack of paper onto his bed before following suit.

It hasn't been a few days, and I'm already beat. Maybe Dad was right, kind of. I should probably clean up my room...nevermind, I am too lazy. Asher sighs, his face pressed into his pillow. *I told them it'll take a week to grade, right? That's a lie, it'll probably take a day or two, max. Eh, at least I can get ahead on my homework.*

Asher sluggishly gets up and walks to his closet, placing his green coat in a hangar. He glances at his reflection in the mirror on the closet door, running his hand through his hair to comb it. *What am I doing? I have the slightest idea what is 'fashionable' or what 'looks good'. Not like I care. Oh, that's surprising. I actually see some muscle forming.* He cleans his glasses with the bottom of his shirt.

Asher retrieves the stack of paper and places it on his desk, then pulls out his phone. *Pretty neat how Euler has their*

own application for grading tests. I'm probably wrong; this'll barely take an evening. Although I'm pretty sure it only works with Euler-made tests, so it will still take a while once I make my own tests. Oh well, that's for future me to deal with.

Asher starts taking photos and flipping through the tests. *What are they, kindergarteners? None of them wrote their names down. Whatever, I am already getting the hang of their identical-sisters quirk.* Once he finishes scanning all six tests, he places his phone down to process.

Hmm, I wonder what Dad made for dinner. I mean, it's always good, so I guess it doesn't matter. A steak would be pretty good, but I am also craving something sweet. He hears a quiet ping. *Oh wow, that was quick. The wonders of technology!*

Asher picks up his phone and begins scrolling through the results. Slowly, his calm demeanor shifts into rapid concern, as his scrolling becomes more frantic. *No, that can't—it can't—there's no way. The app must be bugged; I'll grade it myself.*

“Asher~!” Callie’s high-pitched voice yells across the house. “Daddie says dinner is ready!”

“Give me a second, I need to check something!” Asher yells in response, and a bead of sweat falls down his forehead.

A second passes, then a minute, then an entire hour. The lights in Asher’s room turn off as he hunches over his desk, scratching his head.

I...you’re kidding me. You’re actually kidding me. W-what? What am I looking at? This cannot be real, this cannot...how does anyone...I don’t understand! This one is practically blank! What the fu—!

Chapter 5: Trial by Fire

As if taken over by bloodlust, Asher storms across the school hallways. His eyes twitch with restrained frustration, leaning forward in approach. Asher swings open the classroom door.

“Hey! President!” Asher yells, his anger barely oozing from his words. He slams the entire stack of tests on a nearby table. “Mind if I ask you a question?”

“What do *you* want?” Monette unenthusiastically asks, turning around with a clipboard in her hand. “I’m a little busy. Go away.”

“Yeah! What is your problem?” One person in her circle asks.

“Seriously, dude, stop bothering her.” Another says. *Damn lackeys. I don’t have time for this.*

“Oh, I’m bothering her? I’m *so* sorry,” Asher dramatically responds. “It’s just...I have this thing I *need* to ask her about.” He lifts up one of the tests and begins waving it around. “You see, I am an educator, of sorts. And...when I see such a prominent, distinguished figure of this *esteemed* academy, I can’t help but worry when they are at risk of—”

In a flash, Monette plants her hand on Asher's mouth. A gust trails a few seconds later, with her clipboard clattering shortly after.

"Haha! You're so silly, Asher," Monette laughs uneasily. "What's more important right now is the...the school dance! Yes! W-we can talk about that stuff later." Her smile quivers as she dissuades the concern. Slowly, she turns to Asher with absolute dread. She begins breathing heavily. "D-don't speak of this again. You know what I can do." *Let's not be too hasty now! Judging from her reaction, I'm guessing this isn't the first time. Now I think about it, is this what happened to previous tutors?*

"Queenie. We need to talk about something." The second period arrives, and Asher is a little shook up from his previous encounter. As if talking to a rock, absolutely no movement was shown. *Is she alive?* "Hey, I know you can hear me. This is a serious issue—" Before he could continue, Asher was shushed by numerous other students.

Immediately when the bell rings, Queenie ducks her head and bolts out the door. *Ack, seriously? Well, at least she is alive. So, if that's her reaction, this is definitely not new. Oh no.*

The rest of the girls were a bust. Petra left without noticing Asher's ceaseless cries. Diane seemed to have forgotten the previous ordeal, and Asher, for that matter. Triss decided that the group of boys was important, and Heather was nowhere to be seen.

Not only are all of them avoiding me, but they also seem completely complacent. That irritates me moreso. If they think some threats and silent treatment will deter me, they have another thing coming!

With a surge of 'academic passion', Asher begins his climb up the mountain. Every pedal, he's reminded. Every cycle, he is reinvigorated. *Screw the letter of recommendation! If these brats think they can just continue like nothing's wrong, I'll whip them into shape, if it kills me!*

The sweat continued sliding down Asher's neck. *Who am I kidding? That letter means practically everything. Seriously, why am I doing this to myself? I'm doing mental and physical gymnastics at this point. Man, I am so exhausted.*

Asher begins to pant, his breath flowing between his gritted teeth. *I already biked up this hill before, why does this feel longer!? Oh my god. That's it, I'm riding into incoming traffic.*

“Whatcha doin’?” A female voice asks behind Asher, popping out of nowhere.

“WHAA—” Asher screams, wobbling on his bike. He barely prevents himself from eating ground. “What the—who...” Asher takes a moment to turn around, squinting his eyes. *Tanktop. Blue skirt. Blue eyes.* “Petra,,,”

“Yay, you got it!” Petra beams with glee, as if she didn’t almost kill a man. “You are, like, definitely the smartest person I know!”

“Uh huh, right...” Asher responds unconvinced, getting off his bike and dusting his pants.

“So,” Petra says in a low voice, imitating a general. “What are you doing here, soldier?”

“I’m...I’m, uh...” Asher draws a blank, overwhelmed by the sudden spike of adrenaline. A switch flicks in his brain, and he returns to his original, frustrated state. “I’m here to teach you and the other five disasters!”

“Okay~. Is there something you wanted to show us?” Petra asks, apparently unaware.

Asher glares at her, but decides not to respond. Using a new messenger bag to carry his stuff, he pulls out the stack of tests and spreads them out in his hand, revealing the scores.

“Thirty-two percent. Forty percent. Sixty-two percent. Twenty percent! Fifty-one percent. Fifteen, freaking, percent! None of you scored a passing grade! On a practice test! Focused on review! REVIEW!!! And none, not *one*, of you took the time to write your name down. So I can’t scold any of you properly!” Asher huffs, licking his dry lips.

Petra looks stunned. She looks down, scrunching her eyebrows, as if deep in thought. Closing her eyes, she concentrates, then returns to her blissful expression.

“Yup, that tracks.” Petra smiles. Asher’s jaw metaphorically and physically drops, unable to continue his rant from sheer dumbfoundedness.

“I-I...” Asher stutters, completely at a loss for words. “And you’re fine with this...?”

“Yep, heheh,” Petra softly laughs. “We haven’t been the best at school stuff. Or, at least, since my sisters aren’t here, I haven’t been. I probably got the lowest score.”

“...Did you want to take a look?” Asher asks, his expression disappointed. Petra walks up and looks through each test.

“Oh, huh, that’s kind of funny. The lowest score doesn’t have my handwriting...There it is! Wow, I can’t believe it!”

Petra grabs the test with twenty percent. *Five percent improvement is hardly anything to be proud of.*

“Great, you are reminding me why I’m here, and climbing this dumb road.” Asher re-saddles the bike.

“Wait, are you here to tutor us?” Petra asks, as if she realizes something profound. “I thought you weren’t coming back till next week, right?”

“You remember that, huh?” Asher questions, slightly impatient. “Then you must have remembered something as simple as the quadratic formula, right?” A brief silence.

“Meanie...” Petra playfully pouts, tapping her pointer fingers together. Asher shakes his head, beginning to pedal. “Hey! Where are you going?”

“Didn’t I already tell you? I’m giving you and your sisters an earful!” Asher briefly turns his head around, seeing Petra jogging in pursuit. “Some selective memory you have.”

“No, I mean...why? Nobody is home right now,” Petra says. Again, Asher barely manages to catch himself when he stops.

“Excuse me?” Asher asks, agitated.

“Yeah, everyone else left a while ago.” Petra continues to jog in place. “Monette has a student counseling meeting she

has to attend, and I’m pretty sure about the upcoming school dance. Triss dragged Queenie out of her room to go shopping together. Heather...I think she may have gone with Monette or to the library. And Diane...actually, I don’t know where Diane went, but she isn’t home. So, yeah, that just leaves me~!”

“Are you *kidding* me?” Asher leans back, dejected. *I biked up this damn mountain for NOTHING?* “...Why are you still here then?”

“Who, me?” Petra places her pointer fingers on the edges of her mouth. “Well, I’m too busy with a lot of stuff, so it’s hard for me to help out the school council. As for shopping...I’m not *that* much of a girly girl, so I don’t really mind. Also, Diane likes doing her own thing a lot, so I wouldn’t want to bother her. Oh, I wanted to go running, and then I saw you here~. So...yeah!” *You could have just said that last part.* “Wait, what was the question again?” *She can’t focus on a single thought.*

“...Doesn’t matter...” Asher reluctantly balances his bike on the hind wheel and flips it around, pointing the bike down the hill.

“Huh? Where are you goin’?” Petra asks.

“Home...?” Asher’s voice goes cold.

“HUH?! But why~?” Petra dramatically frowns. *She’s pulling my leg. Seriously, it’s like she can’t put two and two together.*

“...None of your sisters are home, so why bother?” Asher mumbles, emitting a cloud of glum. He begins to spiral, talking to himself. “I don’t have the *slightest* understanding. It’s one thing not to be ahead, I suppose that’s normal, but falling behind *that* badly? Without *any* remorse? I-I can’t...why do none of them seem to care? Heck, why do I care? It’s not like it matters to them.” He sighs, his voice becoming quieter. “Maybe I’m just projecting...Ha! Who am I kidding? I’m only caring because of the incentive. I always do this...”

Amidst his rambling, Asher hardly noticed Petra. Her sunny disposition disappears, replaced by a solemn expression. She slowly circles around Asher as he suffocates in his own mind, calmly thinking. Petra starts smiling again.

“Hey!” Petra yells, right in front of his face.

“AH—yes? What?” Asher yells in response, startled, snapping back to reality.

“You can teach me!” Petra beams. Asher returns to his pessimistic state.

“...I’m going home.” Asher plants his foot on one of the bike pedals.

“WAIT, wait, wait! Hold on!” Petra yells, startling Asher from biking away. “How about...I follow you home?”

“What?” Asher turns back, befuddled.

“I mean, I could run beside while you go home, and you help me out with my studying! How does that sound?” Petra says, hopping in place.

“...You aren’t seriously considering this, are you?” Asher asks, concerned

“Why not?” Petra responds, acting all giddy. Asher places his hand on his chin, calculating.

“I live almost four miles away. That would be eight miles round trip, plus going down and up the steep road.” Asher says, confident that it would deter her.

“That’s okay!” Petra says, seemingly oblivious.

“Are you serious?!” Asher yells, dumbfounded. “That’s about a third of a marathon!”

“Don’t worry about me, I’ll be okay!” Petra smiles.

“Besides, I already told you. I’m not that much of a girly girl!” *What does that mean?*

“You’ve said that twice.” Asher gradually returns to his original, argumentative personality. “First of all, that implies girls aren’t physically capable, which is *subjective* rather than *objective*. Secondly, you’re wearing a skirt...Okay, I may be contradicting my first point, but the point is that’s typically associated with femininity. Hence...girl.”

“Uh...that’s a lot of big words.” Petra scratches the top of her head. “But, I still don’t think so.”

Petra grabs the hem of her skirt. In the span of a few milliseconds, Asher glances at a minuscule crease on the blue fabric. Violently, Asher whips his head and body back, as if shot in the head. He tumbles back, collapsing off his bike.

“Yeah, I’m wearing shorts underneath, so I don’t know,” Petra says cluelessly, looking down. She looks up at the trainwreckin frontt of her. “Whoa! What happened?”

Like a feral animal, Asher finds his footing and pounces at Petra, ensuring that he maintains eye contact. He grabs both of Petra’s hands and sends them down to her waist.

“What happened?! What do you mean?! What is wrong with you?!” Asher screams, blushing profusely.

“But I’m wearing shorts...” Petra trails off, confused. Asher steps back, clasping his hands in front of his face.

“Wearing sh—do NOT do that again, are we clear?”

Asher looks back at Petra with murderous intent.

“Heheh, aye aye, mister!” Petra giggles.

“I swear, I’m going to liquidate your brain for having the audacity, or stupidity, to *flash* me,” Asher grumbles, rubbing his eyes in irritation.

“Whaddya say?” Petra asks, tilting her head and leaning forward. Asher lifts up his bike, dusting off the seat. He takes a deep breath and sighs.

“Nothing. You said for me to teach you, correct? Let’s move.” Asher calmly says.

“Yay~!” Petra responds.

“Wow~! The sunset looks so pretty!” Petra squeals.

“Hey! Stop getting distracted, I *just* asked you a question., Asher calls out, leaning his head back slightly.

From a scene in a boxing movie, Asher bikes in front with Petra not far behind, holding her practice exam paper. though Asher is pedalling slower than usual, Petra is keeping

pace with ease, without any sign of fatigue. Sadly, Asher wished fatigue were the main concern.

“Mmm...what was the question again?” Petra asks, her ponytail swaying up and down with every step. *Holy crap, why is this so difficult?*

“Problem fifteen, which was simple algebra, has a value ten *thousand* times the expected result. Can you *please* tell me how this happened?” Asher repeats, building up a sweat while biking.

“Uhhhh...” Petra drones, looking up while covering her mouth with the test. “I have no idea, haha.” *Are you kidding me right now? How do you not just see it?* “Hey, aren't you supposed to tell me, or something like that? That's, like, what tutors are supposed to do.”

“Well, yes...sometimes,” Asher says, jaded. “But, sometimes, it's the tutor's job to *guide* them. If I told you everything, you wouldn't be able to solve new problems, especially when the reasoning is *simple*. Now tell me, can you see how you got the wrong answer? I wrote the correct one right next to it.”

Searching through the archives of her mind, Petra closed her eyes hard and puffed out her cheeks. After a good

few seconds, Petra looked as if she was about to pass out or asphyxiate herself. Finally, she let out an exaggerated exhale, as if she had an epiphany, all of this occurring while running. Petra opened her mouth, about to say something, then something else caught her gaze.

“Oh my god~!” Petra screams, banking a sharp ninety-degree turn.

“What the—hey!” Asher clamps the brakes, leading to a brief wheelie. He quickly flipped his and chased after Petra. “Where are you going?!”

Petra trails through a narrow, foliage-infested stone path, with Asher angrily approaching. Passing through trees arching over the nearby walls, Asher is constantly pelted by branches. Eventually, Petra reaches the end of the path, crawling under a broken metal fence.

“You have to be joking,” Asher mumbles, out of breath. He slides across a patch of fallen leaves, stopping next to the fence. “This has to be some level of trespassing...Ah, screw it!” Asher hides his bike under a nearby bush, then jumps under the fence. After struggling for a little bit, he gives up and hops over instead.

The setting morphed from suburban city to a deep forest. Asher, briefly forgetting his chase victim, takes a moment to review the scenery. A splash of colors blended together on the forest ceiling, with small insects and critters dancing in the calm air, mesmerizing the simple human. Refocusing himself, Asher returns to the pursuit.

Running blindly in a straight line, Asher slips, forcibly tumbling backwards to prevent himself from falling off the edge of the path. As small rocks and patches of dirt roll down, Asher glances at the area below.

“Hahaha, weeeee~! Woohoo~!” Petra excitedly laughs. From a decent distance, Asher analyzes what seems to be a makeshift playground. A small sandbox is filled with old, forgotten toys fit for children. A slide bent from a flat sheet of metal, with black foam covering the exposed edges, is perched on a tree with nailed wooden planks as steps. Finally, with metal chains strapped to the sturdiest branch on the tallest tree, a large tire swing dangles horizontally, as Petra turns herself into a human tornado.

“Why exactly are we here? I thought we were focusing on studying?” Asher asks, raising his voice to reach Petra.

“But this is so fun~! C’mon, come down here~!” Petra yells, amidst spinning.

“...How many times do you have to get sidetracked?” Asher mumbles to himself, before beginning his descent. “I’m only coming down to drag you back up, got it?”

After stumbling over branches and slipping on leaves, Asher eventually reaches the playground. Immediately, Petra plants her feet on the ground, tossing dirt and leaves as she slows down, which inadvertently covers Asher. He just stands, motionless, with a tired expression.

“Oops, I’m sorry,” Petra apologizes with guilt, covering her mouth with one hand. Widening her puppy dog eyes, she slowly pats a spot on the tire. “Make it up to you?”

“...You cannot be feeling anything else but delight from tormenting me,” Asher says, disheveled and weary.

“I’m not! I swear! I am so, *so* sorry,” Petra squeaks, bowing profusely. Asher sighs.

“If I get on this swing, can you *promise* that I can finish tutoring so I can *finally* go home...please?” Asher asks, dispirited, brushing the rubble off his body. A huge smile grows on Petra’s face.

“Yes! Pinky promise!” Petra pats the spot on the tire faster.

Reluctantly, Asher walks to the tire swing, noticing the structural layout. The large chain from the tree split into three smaller chains, separating the sitting area into thirds. In one of those thirds, Petra swings both her legs in the center of the tire, holding onto two separate chains.

Asher, opposite of gracefully, attempts to climb his way onto the tire. He lifts in with one leg, then hops off the other, shaking the entire swing. He tries lowering his legs, but they accidentally brush against Petra. Frantically, Asher tries to shimmy himself away to make more room. But to no avail, he eventually gives up.

“Wow, your legs are very big,” Petra playfully comments. *What is that comment? How do I respond?*

“Well, you see,” Asher sarcastically begins. “This swing is built for children...and I’m not a child. So, since this was your doing, you had me sit close to you...uncomfortably.” He makes a sly expression, but Petra just giggles.

“You have a point,” Petra says, softer compared to her loud demeanor. “I guess it has been since my sisters and I came here. We were all able to sit and swing together back then.

Brings back memories...” *Oh wow, now you remember something? Well...I suppose it’s sentimental, so I won’t ridicule her about it.*

“Why here? In a rickety, rundown playground in the middle of a forest?” Asher asks, curious. “That’s weird, coming from a batch of rich girls.”

“Haha, maybe, when you put it like that,” Petra says, scratching the back of her head. “The six of us enjoyed hanging out together, a lot more when we were younger. Me and Diane were always exploring and getting into trouble, and usually the rest of our sisters had to rescue us.” *Yep, no arguments there.* “I...don’t think I remember how, but we eventually stumbled across this abandoned playground...so we made this our secret hideout~.”

“Right...you still didn’t answer my question,” Asher presses further. “I don’t understand. Couldn’t you all have gone somewhere cleaner and, frankly, richer?”

“Hey! Just because our family has more money than most people, does not mean we *can’t* do other things,” Petra playfully pouts. “Besides, it was just a way to get away from Dad—” Petra’s expression freezes.

“Uh...did you want to talk about that?” Asher asks, afraid and concerned. Eventually, she reverts back to her happy-go-lucky self.

“Nah, it’s okay!” Petra smiles, jumping off the swing. “Let’s just get started!” With Asher still on the swing, Petra heaves the tire back and forth in a harmonic motion. She grunts, visibly struggling to move the swing.

“You good?” Asher asks.

“Y-yeah, I got this!” Petra responds, panting.

“Are you sure? I can push the swing instead...” Asher asks again, his concern slowly rising.

“No, no, no. Seriously!” Petra smiles while pushing the tire. “B-back then, I was the one who pushed all of us.”

“Dang, making you do all the work?” Asher jokes.

“Look, you are clearly having a tough time, let me—”

“I SAID I GOT IT!” Petra yells, her voice completely different in tone. She stops pushing the swing, covering her mouth.

Was it something I said? Crap, this isn't good... Why am I here again? Oh right, I was tutoring...

“Heheh, woah. I don't know what got in me,” Petra chuckles, looking away. “I, uh...you’re right! We shouldn’t be

here, anyways. Let's just get going!” She stands up and turns around, dusting her skirt. Asher contemplates for a few seconds.

“Here, you get on,” Asher says, jumping off and offering his seat. Petra, reluctantly, turns back to Asher. Her smile wavers.

“Hah, I'm okay, really! You don't need to ” Petra says, lifting the corners of her lips. “Like you said, it's for children...and uncomfortable!”

“Ah ah ah, hush, rich girl,” Asher says slyly. “You brought me here on this side quest. Might as well see it through.” Petra drops her smile, hesitantly walking back to the tire.

Once she was settled, Asher starts pushing the tire back and forth, with more effect. However, Petra remained emotionless, like a stiff mannequin being tossed around. Determined, once reaching a decent height, Asher jumps onto the swing to provide spin.

Like a lightbulb, Petra’s face lit up. She laughed, with her eyes matching her smile. A strange sense of accomplishment filled Asher, infected with a small grin. He

was not paying attention to the speed at which he was going, eventually launching himself off.

“Are you okay?” Petra worriedly asks, stopping the swing.

“...Gnarly...” Asher groans, still winded from the fall. She closes her eyes and giggles.

“You’re so silly!” Petra says. Suddenly, after blinking a few times, she checks her left eye. “Hey, Asher, could you look look around for my contact? I think it may have flew off while we were spinning.”

Asher leans up, noticing the heterochromia girl. He looks around, brushing through the leaves and foliage. Coincidentally, he finds a small clear disk in an already cleared path of leaves, trailing far from the playground. Although interesting, Asher decides to focus on returning the contact.

“Heheh, sorry~,” Petra quietly laughs. She jams the contact back in her eye, making Asher wince. “That was really fun... We should start going, I probably wasted a lot of your time.

“Most of this interaction was on a whim anyways, so generally its fine,” Asher says, trying to comfort the intent behind the burdened positivity. “But, yeah, we should go.”

The trek back to Asher’s house was relatively quiet. No yelling about the practice exam, nor any more long-winded tangents.

“Are you sure you can make it back? I can ask my parents to drive you?” Asher asks, standing at the front door.

“I’ll be fine~! See~?” Petra says, hopping and jogging in place.

“Okay.” There is a long, awkward silence. Asher slowly turns around and reaches for the door, but then stops, “You multiplied.”

“Huh?” Petra asks, stopping her movement and tilting her head in confusion.

“The problem, on the exam,” Asher says. “You multiplied by a hundred instead of dividing. That’s why your answer was ten thousand times bigger than the actual answer. I guess... I was overly frustrated on a simple mistake.”

“...What? What are you talking about?” Petra asks, oblivious.

“W-What do you mean? Problem fifteen?” Asher questions confused, the academic fire returning to him.

“No clue what you are talking about, mister.” Petra smiles, bouncing up and down. Asher rubs his eyes in frustration.

“You cannot be serious right now. What was the point of me tutoring if you don’t remember?” Asher asks, regretting his life choices.

“I dunno,” Petra answers, acting cutesy. “Honestly, I thought you looked very sad, so I thought this would cheer you up!” *I am at a loss for words to describe what I am feeling. What do you MEAN this was for ME? ME tutoring YOU, and it didn’t register that it was supposed to help YOU. God, this is hopeless.* Asher clears his throat.

“From now on, we start having a study session, including your sisters, after school. This is addition to me visiting your home to tutor you there, because this is ridiculous!” Asher yells, back to peak form.

“Okay!” Petra salutes, but then her expression morphs into concern. “Actually, no...I don’t think so.”

“You don’t...think so?” Asher quietly mumbles.

“Yeah, I’m pretty busy right after school,” Petra says. *What the heck can you be busy with?* “Let me think...I have running, volleyball, swimming, cooking, cleaning, volunteering, cheerleading...” *Holy crap, I stand corrected. How busy is this woman? Why does a person need this many activities* “Oh, and I have to go to tutoring! Wait...you’ll already be there.”

Asher crouches down, in gloom. *This is hopeless, this is hopeless, this is hopeless, this is hopeless, this is—*

“Hey, don’t worry!” Petra says, trying to cheer Asher up. “You could definitely ask my sisters! They should be free.”

“Why try...” Asher’s voice trails off. “Pretty much all of them feel like they want to kill me...at least you are actually killing me...”

“Don’t think like that, it’ll be okay.” Petra leans down and pats Asher on the head. “Anyways, none my sisters are as bad as you think, you just got to get to know them. Monette! I am smart enough to see these things, y’know? Just give them a chance, they’ll come around eventually. You got on Diane’s good side.” *What does that mean?* “Don’t worry, I have faith in you!”

Petra hoists Asher from his depressed state and back on his feet. A swirl of mixed feelings circled through Asher, unsure to be hopeful or concerned.

“Well, I’m off, see you at school!” Petra yells, running into the distance.

Welp, that went...somewhere. I guess she is kind of right, I should at least try to make an effort. Then again, she, herself, is making question if I should. Oh well, I could just chalk it up as part of my incentive.

Asher opens the door, where he is met with his father, leaning on a nearby wall.

“So, who’s the girl?” Asher’s Dad says, in a low gravelly voice.

“...How long were you standing there?” Asher says.

Chapter 6: Coin Flip

Before the morning bell rings, Asher finds himself sitting on a bench, looking at the practice exams in his hands. *Alright, new strategy—kill them with kindness! What’s that saying again? Something with honey...doesn’t matter.*

As their tutor, it is my duty to gain their trust, so I can lead them to success. Like a general, gracefully gallivanting on his steed, I must raise my flag and charge into battle. I must inspire my fellow soldiers, bolstering them to march on too! He checks the grades again. if...it’s hopeless.

Asher leans forward, crumpling his body as he jams the papers into his head. *I’m doomed...*

As the chimes of the hellish gong in his ear, Asher solemnly heads to first period, holding the stack of paper close to his chest. Opening the door, to his dismay, no shade of white was to be seen. *Figured.*

Asher sits down at his seat, center column, second row. He turns around, watching Monette’s group chattering amongst themselves at the back of the classroom.

“Did you hear about last night?” One of them asks.

“I’m telling you...” Another goes on.

“Monette has to stay for *how long!*?” Another exclaims. *Judging by their conversation, I’m guessing Monette is busy with her president-student counsel responsibilities. That probably means she is off the table for today...Geez, I am eavesdropping like a total creep! Maybe the ‘tuplets were right about that.*

Quietly, Asher pulls out his textbook and starts taking notes. *I doubt she’d want to interact with me anyways. Rightfully so, I guess. Thinking back, I could of worded things better...and I could have analyzed my emotions better...*

The class is set off without any ruckus. Asher keeps to himself throughout the entire time. *Funny, it finally feels like last year. I wonder...do I prefer the headache or the silence?*

With the first period bell ringing, Asher collects his supplies and walks out the door more encouraged; more determined. *I’m down one, but I shouldn’t fold just yet. It’s my responsibility to put the first foot forward, so I’ll try to take Petra’s word. I’ll get Monette’s favor eventually.*

Entering the science room, Asher is greeted a more animated statue. The green hoodie rustled and shook to the sound of subtle, but violent, scribbling. Although he placed his

bag down fairly loudly, there was no reaction to Asher’s presence.

“Are you drawing something?” Asher asks, trying to sound friendlier. Without eye contact nor sound, materials were scooped up and quickly shoved into a nearby bag. Suddenly, the statue became motionless again. “Hey...I wasn’t trying to startle you.”

the commotion from the other students could not drown out the dreadful silence forming at Asher’s table. *Crap, should I say something? I don’t want to make her uncomfortable, but if I don’t say anything she’ll just ignore me. Then I bet she will run away like last time! Gah, how does a reasonable person act in this situation? Maybe she’s just shy about what she is doing, I’ll change the subject.*

“So...how have you been liking science so far?” Asher asks, preventing the desperation from showing. *Yes! Good small talk! Amazing!*

“...Mm...” Queenie squeaks, barely registering as sound. *What the heck was that? Does that count as human speech? God is punishing me right now. One sister feels like I am talking to someone as dumb as bricks, another is like talking to a pile of them!*

“Cool, cool. I’m personally for the labs and experiments this year. It’s really awesome to see stuff on paper shown in real life. Don’t you think so too?” Asher confidently beams. False confidence, obviously. *Great, showing my thoughts, allowing her to feel comfortable sharing her own!*

“...Yeah...” Queenie whispers. *Okay...that was at least an audible word. But come on, really? That’s it? How are these sisters so different.*

Switching tactics, Asher waits for the end of class, without bothering Queenie any further. Forming his fingers into a triangle and laying his face on his thumbs, Asher watched quietly. Whether a lion, tiger, or any other predatory animal, Asher stalked his prey with focus and diligence.

The moment sound from the intercom was rung, movement was made. Queenie swooped off her seat and hurried over to the door. However, this time, Asher was prepared.

“Wait!” Asher yells, dashing an instant after her. A ruckus began to brew, as the two made their way through the bustling hallway.

With a straight shot, Asher winds up like some bootleg superhero and bolts forward. Swiftly catching up, he whips

around the timid girl. Reaching out, Asher grabs Queenie’s wrist, which was tucked beneath her chest. He briefly slides across the slick floor.

“Just hear me out!” Asher exclaims. With their debacle directly center of the hallway, numerous eyes turned, filled with curiosity. The passionate words resonated through the entire school, with students whispers and clamoring about a possible, juicy confession.

Queenie, on the other hand, was filled with dread. Whimpering, she tried running away, but her effort only led to her smudging the ground beneath her feet.

“Let’s skip the cliché chase sequence, okay? This is more important than that,” Asher says. Ooo’s and ah’s circulated across the campus, with a small circle forming around the two. “I am tired of running, and I am tired of chasing...” The roar of the crowd grew louder.

Attempting other options to escape, Queenie firmly plants her feet and tries to pull away. She uses her free hand to grip the other and tug harder, but Asher barely budged.

“I spoke with your sister, and she told me I shouldn’t give up on you. That I should keep trying!” Asher dramatically exclaims, unaware of the crowd he was stirring up.

“Uh...um...I...!” Queenie squeaks, overwhelmed by the entire situation. Her fear skyrockets, realizing she was chained to a stone wall.

“I know this will benefit you greatly, and I think you will enjoy it too.” Asher says, the crowd filled with anticipation as his bravado grows to an all time high. “Please, meet me after school. I can show you—AUUUUGHAAAACK!!!”

Ow...What the...? Delirious, Asher slowly opens his eyes, daunted by the hum of iridescent lights. *Oh, the room is spinning! I think I passed out...or knocked unconscious?*

He checked his surroundings without lifting his head. Long curtains, shiny floors, and a small bed with a confused Asher. *Yep.*

Groggily, Asher hoists himself up, the soft blanket rolling down his body. He shifts slightly, pulling back a small part of the curtain, peaking at the daylight. *Afternoon already..*

Wincing from pain, Asher opens the rest of the curtain. A quaint nurses office, compared to the prestige of the school. Many small medical beds were spread across a relatively small

room, with a sink at the far end. Each bed vacant and their curtains swung open.

Asher’s bed resided deep, furthest from the door, right next to the window. Coincidentally, his bed was also closest to a visitors couch, with a familiar hoodie. A similar incessant scribbling could be heard, with Queenie glancing up for a brief moment. She looks back down. Then looks back up again. Then, chaos ensues.

“Ah, oh! I-I am—I am s-so...y-you, I...*ahh~!*” Queenie stuttered, making strange noises while on the verge of tears. She quickly places her notebook on the couch, bolting towards Asher’s bedside. She sporadically motioned his hands around, attempting to figure out what to do.

“...Huh?” Asher asks, still mentally recovering.

“I’M SORRYYY!” Queenie wails, now in tears. “Y-you were...and I-I wasn’t sure what to do and...people were there and...I wasn’t sure how strong the kick was supposed to be! She only showed me She only showed me how to, not how hard or when to or...anything about how deal with what happens after!”

“What? Could you slow down—?” Asher asks.

“Ah! Right! Sorry!” Queenie clasps her hands, covering her mouth. “Am I rambling? I’m rambling, aren’t I!? Oh no...this always happens.” Asher tries to wave at Queenie, but she spirals within her own bubble. “I’m so sorry, I’m not good at talking, and always mess up when I say something. Then I try to fix what I said, then mess up again then...W-wait, am I supposed to be here? Oh no! OH NO! Is the door locked? It’s such a small room...I deserve this, don’t I?”

“...Seriously, what are you talking about—” Asher tries to say something.

“Please, I beg you, kill me before you bury me!” Queenie blurts. “I-I don’t like tight spaces...or dark spaces. Wait no, I guess I do, I think it depends. Maybe I don’t like being put in tight, dark spaces against my will. A-and tell my sisters, they’ll worry about me too much and spend too much time looking for me. Wait, you wouldn’t want to reveal yourself, what am I saying? WAIT, you aren’t going to *kill* me, are you? Just don’t let them look at my—”

“STOP!” Asher yells, shocking himself how loud he was. Queenie made a singular cheep, before curling herself into a ball on the couch. She wraps her arms around her legs, hiding

her face behind her knees. “Sorry for yelling...but give me a second to process, okay?”

A drawn out pause echoes through the small room. Asher waits for his adrenaline to subside before saying anything further.

“First, I want to get one thing straight, I am not going to hurt you,” Asher states. “I have no idea where you got that notion from. I am definitely not here to *kill* anyone, understood?”

“...Uh...” Queenie quietly mumbles. “T-then why did you grab my arm...?”

“I told you,” Asher sternly says. “I’ll be honest, I’m not the best runner. I didn’t want to chase you through the entire school just to get your attention. I needed to ask you something and then I was going to let go.”

“...So you weren’t going to drag m-me into a back alley...and...and...” Queenie mutters.

“What the!? No, of course not! What!?” Asher yells, appalled. She tightens her grip on her legs. Her breathing hastens.

“Sorry!” Queenie apologizes, burying her face deeper. “I am s-so, so, so sorry! I thought...you...I needed...self-defence...I...” She begins hyperventilating.

“Just...” Asher says, trying to speak soothingly. “Whatever happened, it’s fine, alright? You don’t need to apologize.”

“But I...” Queenie sniffles. “I thought...you were trying to...take advantage of m-me. S-so I, may have...kicked you.” Queenie blushes. “In...the balls...” *Ah.*

That explains why I feel like my ancestors are screaming at me. I guess the bloodline ends with me...wait, I got Percy.

“Please have mercy~!” Queenie cries.

“Look...it’s...fine.” Asher contemplates, pinches the bridge of his nose. “I’ve never been in a situation like this, so I have no clue how to rectify it. That said...I did grab your arm. I should of used a different solution, and...I am sorry.” He looks up at Queenie. “Your turn.”

“Right! Sorry!” Queenie sheepishly squeaks, standing up. “I won’t kick you in the balls...again! Sorry!”

“Really?” Asher exclaims, squinting his eyes.

“Ah! I’m sorry! W-was that not what I was supposed to say? Oh no...” Queenie panics, concern brewing on her face.

“You gotta stop apologizing.” Asher tries to search for words. “Well I mean, apologies are supposed to address the underlying problem? Yeah, that’s what you did, but *why* you did that is more important.” Asher scratches the back of his head. “Saying ‘sorry’ without knowing what you did is meaningless. And, more importantly, why the...other person did what they did, and why that...led you...to do what you did.”

Queenie stares at Asher, as if he recited some ancient incantation. Her eyes riddled with confusion. *Is this not common knowledge?*

“Sorry, I’m rambling now.” Asher scratches his head, trying to reword his thoughts. “What I mean is...we’re trying not to repeat this again, right? The first step to understand and address it...I guess...I don’t know what I’m saying...”

Queenie sits back down and sulks behind her knees. A long session of thought plays in her mind. Soon, a thought forms.

“I think...I shouldn’t have run away...before,” Queenie mumbles. “I just...get s-scared...and I...was afraid of you.”

“Me?” Asher asks. “Why me?”

“No, that’s not...” Queenie shakes her head. “I was...it was the practice test you gave. I just knew...” She leans her head back down.

Asher looks down at his hands. *I’ve been acting childish and unprofessional. It’s not fair for me to put the same expectations I have on myself on them. The whole point is for me to help them. I wouldn’t have been asked to be here if they didn’t.*

“I said this earlier, but,” Asher says, “I interacted with one of your sisters. I realized, I need to take this job more seriously. I’ll be blunt, all your scores sucked. But...I’ll support the six of you, and hopefully you can still graduate with your...seriously crappy scores.” *How did you managed to pass last year?* “So, will you help me?”

“Me? But...w-why me? N-not my sister?” Queenie asks, sniffing while lifting her head up.

“Well...” Asher scratches the back of his head. “Honestly...I thought you were the easiest to manipulate...sorry.” Queenie quietly laughs.

“That’s fair,” Queenie says. *Wow, I was not expecting that reaction.* “I would think the same if I was you.” *Man, self depreciation much?*

“So,” Asher says, stretching. “I am pretty sure the Euler library is still open. Do you think we can stop by and review the test?”

“...Sure.” Queenie responds with slight hesitance. She stands up, collects her things, and walks to the door. Asher begins to follow, throwing the blanket off himself. Then, he is stunned.

“Um...” Asher says, looking down. “Why do I have different pants?” The hood shadows the girl’s eyes. Suddenly, Queenie hides her face in shame.

“You may have...peed your pants...in the middle of the whole school...” Queenie crumples to the floor. “Please forgive me!!!”

Ah. Welp, there goes my reputation and dignity...if I had any. Time to walk into oncoming traffic.

Head down, hands shading eyes, and slouching forward. Asher walked through school, his expression blank. He took quick glances through his fingers, surveying the nearby students.

“What do I do now...?” Asher complains, under his breath. With each stifled laugh and every concerned stare, Asher’s paranoia only grows. He sharply turns around. “Why are you so far away? Get over here!”

Queenie pops out from behind a nearby bush and scampers towards Asher. She, too, keeps her head down, pulling at the seams of her hood.

“S-sorry...” Queenie whimpers. “It’s just...so many people are l-looking at us...” She pulls her arms close to her chest, fidgeting with her hands.

“Gee, I wonder why?” Asher sarcastically remarks between his teeth. “Why are *you* embarrassed, anyways? You weren’t the one who keeled over and wet themself. Also, stop apologizing!”

“Well I-I, this—” Queenie stutters. “I have...never...I don’t know what I’m s-supposed...” Her eyes jolt from side to side. “So many people are watching!”

“...I suppose we are stuck in this together,” Asher mumbles. The two of them sulked quietly through the courtyard, making their best attempt to avoid attention. By avoiding it, however, they bring more eyes to themselves.

Asher glances beside him. As their trek continues, Queenie’s breathing begins to quicken. Her face scrunches and her grip tightens. The fabric from her hoodie begins to crumple, matching the expression on the timid girl.

Asher looks up. *Statistically speaking, it’s impossible for everyone at this school to have the incident. With social media, maybe the number is bigger, but still not a hundred.* Dramatically, Asher lowers his hands to his side, gracefully staring up at the sky while inhaling the cold air. He sighs.

I have no idea why I am worrying so much. I doubt enough people care to have it affect me. It’s so clear to me now! I’m not delusional; I’m not coping! It’s just mathematical! Queenie steps back, startled by Asher’s divine vision. He coughs. *I need to stop monologing in my head.* Suddenly, Asher hears something; wheels crackling on gravel.

“Screw it,” Ashers says, before absolutely booking it through the rest of the courtyard. His sprinting completely catches Queenie off guard.

“W-wait!” Queenie yells, still quiet though. She scurries behind him.

With a bang, Asher slams himself through the glass double-doors of the library. He stumbles, rolling forward until slamming his face onto the floor. Quickly, Asher stands back up, eyes twitching.

“Eheh, ha, haha...HAHAHAHA,” Asher tweaks, suppressing his laugh before going full-blown. He turns around, witnessing the completely appalled expression from the librarian, Asher immediately composes himself, then realizes he is out of breath. “Sorry. Ma’am.”

A little later, Queenie scurries into the library. She makes sure to keep some distance from the psychopath. After checking in, they walk through the famous Euler library. Containing multiple floors of shelves and couches. One floor in particular had rows of small, glass, study rooms placed side-by-side, which Asher and Queenie perused through.

“Occupied, occupied, occupied...someone is sleeping in there,” Asher says, looking through each room.

“Why do we need a room?” Queenie asks. “There are chairs...and tables...out here.”

“I know, but the rooms here are sound proof. Great for berating people without questioning looks,” Asher answers, with a straight face. Queenie holds her notebook up and covers her face. “Occupied, occupied, occupied...”

After minutes of walking through the large library, to his luck, Asher notices an recognizable shade of white.

“Jackpot!” Asher exclaims to himself, picking up speed. He does not gently open the door, entering with an archaic accent. “Greetings! I have come to commandeer this academic abode!”

Sitting alone, the sister looks up and pulls down the headphones from her ears. She tilts her head, unfazed. A quick scan around the room; two long rectangular tables, an assortment of spinny chairs, and an unplugged, relatively new tv mounted to the beige wall.

“Um...” Asher drops the accent. “Yeah, I’m too tired for this...Erm, which sister are you?” The sister’s expression shifts.

“Geez, did you fall on your head or what?” She snarky comments, holding a condescending smile. Asher marches out the door.

“This one’s no good, retreat!” Asher dramatically exclaims. Once Asher stops obstructing the doorway, Queenie rushes in, planting her face on her sister's lap. “Uh...”

“Heheh, I’m just messing with you. Come in,” She says, gently. Cautiously, Asher creeps back in and slowly closes the door. “My impression was good, right?”

“Probably...” Asher pulls himself a seat. “Was it one of your sisters?”

“Yep! She puts on this fun ‘mean-girl’ persona, so it's super fun to copy,” The sister giggles. *So she was acting?* “You okay, Asher?”

Ah crap, I need a better poker face. Why do they have to look the same? Quickly, focus! I've been Queenie most of the day, so it's obviously not her. Petra said she is busy after school, and she doesn't seem to be the type to study by herself. This sister said she was imitating a ‘mean-girl’, I bet she’s talking about...Triss? Maybe Monette? Both of them don't seem to be fond of me, so I doubt it's either of them. That means she must be Heather...right? Wait a minute, could she be Diane? Damn, I don't have a read on her, and she seems to be the type to mess with me. Honestly, I don't think I have a good read on any of them. Which one are they? Shoot, I've been thinking

about this too long, haven't I? I need to say something before this gets more awkward...but I don't know! Why is this so hard!? AHHH!

“N-nothing, everything is fine,” Asher says, trying to salvage the situation. “Hea...Di—”

“Heatherrr~!” Queenie squeals, teary-eyed as she sniffles. *Dang it! I was right the first time!* Heather pulls Queenie’s hood back and softly caresses the top of her head. Blissfully content, Queenie smiles.

“Oh, did something happen between you two?” Heather asks, playing with her sister’s. Immediately, like a child caught with a handful of chocolate, Queenie jumps and puts her hood back on. Grumbling, she curls onto a chair in the corner. “I assume so.”

“Queenie physically abused me,” Asher snitches, his expression blank. He points at Queenie without turning.

“Bu—W-wha—I—” Queenie sputters. “I said I was sorry!”

“A ‘sorry’ won’t fix stain you have made on my life, literally and figuratively.” Asher pesters slyly, mostly to mess with Queenie. He smirks contently.

“*Hua~.*” Queenie hides her face with her sleeves. Throughout the whole ordeal, Heather was covering her mouth as she quietly laughed,

“Seriously, Queenie? What has Diane been teaching you?” Heather asks, smiling. *What? What did Diane teach her?* Placing her elbows on the table, Heather rests her chin on her wrists. “So, Asher, what’s the reason for this visit?”

Asher’s smirk grows larger; his sleeper agent activates. He stands up, pulls out the dreaded stack of tests, and slams it on the table. Queenie squeaks, while Heather’s headrest crumbles.

“Your reckoning!” Asher exclaims, morphing his previous frustration into exaggeration. “I have you trapped in your own prison! And now, I shall inflict my revenge—”

“Oh, thank you. I wanted to review it when I got the chance,” Heather says, moving up to Asher to find her test. Asher slowly sits back down, his dropping the theatrics.

“I’m planning on hosting an extra study session for you and your sisters. None of you received a good score,” Asher says, dryly.

“Really? That’s a shame,” Heather says, pursing her lips. “Good idea though.” Asher turns to Queenie.

“Did you want to review?” Asher asks, signaling with head. Timidly, Queenie scuttles behind Heather and starts looking for test. Intrigued, Asher his peaks over the two.

Oh, Heather got the sixty-two score? It’s not good, but I guessed that was Monette’s. Queenie got forty, middle of the pact. Still not good.

“Aw, I thought I did a lot better. Oh well, that’s why you’re here,” Heather says, turning to Asher. *I don’t know if I should be glad you want me, or mad that you need me.*

Both turn to Queenie, methodically flipping through each page. With every turn, Queenie’s face begins to gain a red hue from embarrassment. Whimpering, Queenie turns bright red once she finishes skimming.

“Woah, you two *are* sisters,” Asher ponders, placing his hand on his chin. Flustered, Queenie crouchs down and pulls her hood completely over her face, her embarrassment seeping through fabric. Heather lowers herself as well, comforting her sister.

“There, there,” Heather calmly says. Asher tilts his head in amusement.

“I haven’t known you six for that long, but I assume you of the group,” Asher says, looking down at Heather.

“Oh, funny you mention that,” Heather says, pulling out a chair and sitting back down. “I’m actually the youngest.”

“I still don’t understand, how can any of your sisters be the ‘youngest’ or ‘oldest’?” Asher asks, sitting down as well. “Aren’t you all the same age? That is part of ‘identical’.”

“Oh, well, you see,” Heather begins, slightly blushing. “When a woman gives birth, it takes a lot of energy. Since me and my sisters are sextuplets, we...how should I say...popped out one by one. I was popped out last, that makes me the youngest!”

“And?” Asher questions, unfazed. “I highly doubt a few seconds difference while the six of your brains are mush makes a significant impact on your dynamic. If you change the order, nothing would happen.”

“I’ll have you know,” Heather confidently begins. She stands up, placing one hand on her hip and holds her hand out. “The order matters greatly!” Dramatically, Heather lifts her thumb. “My oldest sister, Monette, is the coolest, serious, most diligent person I know! She’s so hard working, and is such a good school president.”

Didn’t you get the highest score?

“My second oldest sister, Diane,” Heather says, lifting her index finger. “She is so tough, cool, and defiant. I see her as our guardian angel; our sworn protector!”

Protector? I don’t see it. Then again, I don’t really see anything with her. Heather grabs her middle finger.

“My third oldest sister, Triss, is such a goddess!” Heather says. “Stylish, bold, and popular with the boys, what is she not? It’s like she is never afraid to speak her mind. So cool!”

Um, is that a good thing? She comes across as evil sometimes.

“My fourth oldest sister,” Heather says, pointing her ring finger at Queenie. “Queenie may be a little shy, but she is so sweet. Plus, her drawing skills are super, duper awesome! You look at them, they are really cool!”

“Heyyy~! You’re embarrassing me!” Queenie covers her face.

“My fifth oldest sister, Petra, is the biggest ball of sunshine,” Heather giggles. “She’s fun and giddy, so excited to do so many things! It’s harder to find things she doesn’t do.”

And yet, she scored second lowest.

“Finally, there is me!” Heather places both hands on her hips, in triumph.

“So, how exactly does this relate to the order?” Asher asks, leaning on the table. Heather takes a moment to think, then quietly sits back down, twiddling her thumbs.

“Heheh, I don’t know,” Heather chuckles. “I just wanted to gush about my amazing siblings.”

“Amazing, huh?” Asher sarcastically remarks, looking away while resting his face on his knuckles. “As great as you make them out to be, are any of them here?”

“Well, there are two of us, right?” Heather walks over and puts her hands on Asher’s shoulders. He immediately brushes them off.

“Two out of six is not close to a passing grade,” Asher mumbles. “Heck, it’s a better grade than half of these tests.”

“That’s not very nice,” Heather says, upset. She crosses her arms. “It is your job to help us out, is it not? Have *you* made an effort yet?”

“Effort?” Asher stands up, his voice freezes the air in the small room. He turns around, cold staring at Heather. “Monette risks my job every time I interact with her. Triss seems like she has a vendetta against me. I had to go on a wild

goose chase with Petra, and I have no idea if it was productive. I can barely understand Diane and what she is thinking.” Asher points to Queenie. “And I almost lost my ability to procreate thanks to her!” Queenie stays quiet. “So yeah, I apologize if I feel a little apprehensive, but I believe I am making as much effort as I can.”

The staredown continues. The atmosphere becoming thicker and thicker by the second. Neither seemed to budge, with Queenie in the background panicking. Eventually, Heather slowly sits.

“I’m sorry,” Heather says, averting her gaze. “I didn’t mean it that way...” Asher is taken aback. He thinks for a moment, then sits down as well.

“I...” Asher cuts himself off, slumping on the table. “I do...appreciate you making effort to help me. And...I understand you think highly of your sisters. But...” Suddenly, he feels a warmth on the top of his head.

“It’s fine,” Heather calmly says, patting Asher’s head. “I understand. For an outsider, it makes sense that my sisters can be overwhelming sometimes.”

“Don’t treat me like a child,” Asher grumbles, pulling Heather’s hand off. “Or...however you treat your sisters.”

Chapter 7: All In

“Heheh, sorry,” Heather says, backing off. “How about this; after you help me with reviewing my test, I’ll help you win the favor of the rest of my sisters. Deal?” She holds out her hand. Asher smirks.

“Just like last time, huh?” Asher turns around and shakes her hand. “Out of the six of you, I can confidently say you are the most rational.”

“You’d be surprised,” Heather laughs. She walks over and sits down across from Asher. “Okay! Let’s get started! Queenie, will you be joining us?” Queenie doesn’t respond. “Queenie? Queenie!?...QUEENIE!?”

“Hmm?” Queenie reaches into her hood and takes off her headphones. “Ah, uh, r-right! Sorry...” She mumbles, timidly scurrying from her corner. Briefly looking up, takes a moment to think, then sits beside Heather.

Two out of six...definitely not passing. But, it's progress.

Euler is a big school, and when I say big, I mean BIG. Like stupid big, especially for a high school. In most cases, students will go there entire four years without exploring the entire campus. I think of myself more curious than most, but I don't venture off to certain areas.

“Where the heck is she?” Asher mutters, briskly walking. He makes subtle glances left and right, making sure he does not stare at one person for too long. *I regret agreeing to this.*

“What do you mean you won’t?” Heather asks, during a flashback.

“Are we talking about *the same* Nine-Point?” Asher asks, hearing something absurd while packing up his material. “What do you think? I’d stick out like a sore thumb.”

“Aww,” Heather coos, like she saw a cute baby. “Is the super serious Asher shy? Is he afraid of a few girls?”

“What the—I am not!” Asher blurts, slightly blushing.

“It's okay, it's perfectly normal for a boy your age to feel this way,” Heather teases, having a smile that makes it

difficult to know if she is being condescending. Sitting at the table, Queenie giggles.

“You—!” Asher turns and glares at Queenie, trying his best to hold his tongue. “I...thank you for partaking in the lesson, but I will *smite* you if you laugh at me again. And you!” He whips back to Heather. “Maybe I didn’t read the fine print before, but I chose to continue dealing with the six of you. So no, I am not afraid of the opposite gender. I am more afraid of getting a migraine from your shenanigans.” Immediately, Heather gasps.

“So there must be another reason, huh?” Heather says, giddy, covering her mouth.

“Wait I—” Asher sputters, realizing he is backed into a corner. “Damnit, just drop it.”

“C’mon, tell me!” Heather pouts.

“I’m a little...curious...too,” Queenie mumbles, peaking from under her hood.

“Tell us!” Heather giggles, leaning on the desk and winking.

Hubris; the bane of my existence. If only I kept my mouth shut. Returning to the present, Asher continues to scour for any semblance of white hair.

At the far west of campus lies the clubs-and-recreational center, nicknamed Nine-Point. I am pretty sure the nickname comes from the geometric concept, but I’m guessing people think it comes from the roof architecture. That’s beside the point.

Compared to the entire campus, especially in the morning, Nine-Point has the largest congregation of girls. I got no clue why this is, but typically, I stay FAR away. I’m not in any clubs!

“Finally, found you,” Asher sighs, relieved. “For how flashy you and your sister’s are, you are surprisingly difficult to find.”

“Um...the hell do *you* want, *stalker*?” The girl lowers her phone down to her waist, placing her free hand on her hip.

Nine-Point, recently renovated, consists of numerous gyms, indoor pools, and a huge field connected by spacious hallways. These hallways are partitioned by large glass windows with a row of lockers. The girl was quietly leaning on one of these lockers, alone, before Asher showed up.

“Insults without being flustered,” Asher grins. “At least you’re making my job a little easier.”

“What are you talking about?” Triss asks. She scoffs before beginning to walk away. “Whatever. Get lost, creep.”

“Hey, hold on,” Asher says, reaching out his hand. He immediately reels back. “Could you stop for a second, I need to talk to you.”

“Make me, loser,” Triss sneers, her words spilling venom.

“Please no,” Asher responds, filled with concern. “I already had a...run-in, with your sister.” Triss stops in her tracks, and pauses for a moment. She lifts a hand over her mouth, before turning around.

“Wait...that was *you*!?” Triss slyly exclaims. Her hand barely covered the amusement spilling out of her grin, and her guile radiated from her eyes. She stifles, before erupting into laughter.

“W-What are you talking about?” Asher asks, feigning ignorance.

“Dang, I wish I was there to see it,” Triss giggles, wiping a tear from her eye. “I heard that Queenie put someone on a stretcher. Knowing that it was *you* is *gold*!”

“You...heard?” Asher’s face goes pale.

“Surely you aren’t *that* stupid,” Triss snickers. “This is the story of the century. Everyone knows, and I mean *everyone*.”

“Ah,” Asher mutters. A bead of sweat runs down his face. His brain shutting down. *That’s that. My future is over.*

“The look on your face is *priceless*!” Triss erupts into laughter again.

“Yes, that is, yep...” Asher says robotically. *Crap, I need to change the subject. Now!* “*Ahem*, your sisters, including you, bombed the practice test. From now on we’ll be having additional tutoring sessions at the library.” Triss’ expression drops.

“*Tsk*, way to kill the mood,” Triss scowls.

“Was...there a mood to begin with?” Asher asks confused, slowly regaining his composure. She rolls her eyes.

“Damn, you are *such* a buzzkill,” Triss grimaces. “You stalked me *just* to tell me I’m *stupid*!?”

“I mean, if that’s how you take it...yes,” Asher says, expressionless. “And, for your information, I did not stalk you. Heather informed me about where you’d be.” Triss’ mouth opens, horrified.

“Are you *kidding* me?” Triss frowns. She stands stiff and looks away, clenching one of her fists. “How would she even...*Augh!* She is *always* like this, paying attention to stupid little details about me. That girl needs to mind her own business.”

“I’d think I’d like it if someone paid me that kind of attention,” Asher blurts, showing a small grin.

“Um, now *you* need to mind *your* own business. Maybe that’s why no one gives you attention,” Triss hisses, making Asher involuntarily step back. She crosses her arms and shakes her head. “That *snitch* should feel ashamed for helping an idiotic *creep*.” Asher’s grin disappears.

“At this point, I don’t feel offended. But, damn,” Asher says, scratching the back of his head. “I am surprised you’re rude to your sisters.”

“Do you think I care?” Triss exclaims, storming up to Asher. She presses her finger onto his chest, making him slightly flinch. “I don’t need a snot-nosed *nobody* telling me anything!” Asher gasps.

“But...but...Petra gave me faith that I could help you. Are you sure you’re okay with breaking your sister’s heart?” Asher whimpers, giving his best puppy-dog eyes. He grabs the

remaining tests from his backpack and lifts them in front of his face. “Don’t worry, I’ll help you with your academics!”

“Oh, my *God!* Are you trying to guilt trip me with my siblings? You can’t keep your mouth shut, can you?” Triss exclaims, slapping Asher’s hands. She grabs her phone from her pocket and begins texting. “I told you, we are *not* friends. Stop trying to act like we are.”

The three remaining tests flutter to the ground, followed by a loud crash, silencing any nearby commotion. Many bystanders turn and observe, as Asher stands silently. His demeanor frosts the nearby walls by the immediate shift in tone. He glances around the room.

“I was humoring your behavior before, but this is getting old,” Asher says, emotionless. “Pick those up.”

“Are you *deaf?* I said ‘make me, loser’,” Triss sneers, smiling down at her illuminated rectangle. She barely acknowledges Asher’s presence. He goes silent again.

“Please...don’t make me get bothered by something so petty,” Asher says.

“You bothered me first, *genius*,” Triss mocks

“I...don’t understand. You know you failed, yet you treat me and the situation like...this? I don’t...get it,” Asher

mutters, staring blankly at fallen tests.

“Dude, can you just quit already?” Triss exasperates, rolling her eyes. “What you need to *get* is a life. No one cares about these stupid books, these stupid tests, or these stupid grades. Why do you think nobody likes you? I bet you’re just compensating for the things you don’t have. I got better things to do than to talk to you.”

“...” Asher doesn’t respond. He looks around.

“*Tsk*,” Triss chuckles to herself, amused. “I don’t know why I dealt with you for this long. Whatever.” She turns around and slowly walks while texting.

Downcast, Asher crouches down and picks up the tests. He dusts them off before holding them under his armpit. He looks around, glances back at Triss, then looks down at the floor. Asher furrows his eyebrows.

“Fine, one less entitled *child* to deal with,” Asher says, under his breathe. A mix of frustration, guilt, and concern swirl within him. “You’re probably just lashing out because you did the worse out of your sisters. Maybe just to spite me.”

Asher’s words too easily cut through the frigid. Triss plants herself in place. Barely audible, a hairline crack forms under her thumb, pressing deeply into the expensive screen.

“You think you can talk down to me?” Triss mumbles, slowly turning her head. Completing her half-rotation, Triss lunges at Asher with ferocity. “Give me that!”

Triss yanks at the stack of paper, which Asher continues to cling to.

“What the heck are you doing? Stop it!” Asher shouts, engaging in a tug of war.

“Give it to me~!” Triss yells, reeling back to gain more leverage.

With a slight tear growing, Asher reluctantly lets go. Triss is sent flying backwards, stumbling before landing on the floor. Angrily, she begins flipping through pages, disregarding her degrading position.

“Really? I take a *single* nudge at your ego, and this is how you react?” Asher says, astounded. “I can’t believe—” The quiet witness only amplifies the subtle sounds that echoed across the halls. Footsteps. Far away chatter. Rattling from small wheels. *CRAP!*

“Are you kidding me? She didn’t fill in half the questions. Can’t believe that jerk lumped her with me,” Triss muttered to herself, continuing to scan through the paper. “Hah! You can shut your stupid mouth!” She dramatically lifts

her test, adorning a wonderful score of thirty-two. Triss' hair slowly slides off her face once she looks back up. "See? Now you'll think twice before saying...that...to me?"

Triss stands back up, confused. She places the stacks of paper on the floor and re-adjusts her hair ribbons. After spinning around countless times, Triss realizes Asher has completely vanished. She clenches that fist.

"...Jerk," Triss mutters. She turns around and decides to leave, with a level of unease in her eyes. Eventually, she quickly scurries back around to collect the tests. "...Stupid nobody."

After turning the corner, Triss yelps in fear as she jumps back a few feet.

Asher partially crouches against the wall. His face is flushed with red, his eyes widened, and his breathing sporadic. *How did I forget?! How could I forget?! This is why I never come to Nine Point! NEVER! What was I thinking?* Asher clutches at his chest, the grey fabric wrinkling under his hand. *I'm such an idiot!*

"The hell is up with you?" Triss asks, leaning back with a questioning look. Asher's eyes dart up, and instantly dropped down to the floor.

"N-nothing," Asher stutters, gulping from fear. He stands back up with a slight wobble and stares at the ceiling. His inhale has a slight uneasiness. "C-could you stop...staring at me?"

"Don't tell me what to do," Triss bites back, Awkward silence arises. Asher slowly calms his breathing.

"Aren't you going to continue taunting or something?" Asher prodded, still shellshocked like a veteran soldier.

"*Tsk*, give me a break," Triss huffed, rolling her eyes. She crosses her arms, switching her glance between Asher and the end of the hallway. Subtly, a small circle forms between Triss' lips. "Oh~."

"Alright, I think we got off on the wrong foot," Asher says. He sighs, letting go of his chest and shaking his whole body to get rid of the adrenaline. Asher turns towards Triss, placing both his hands on his hips. "Let's just start from the beginning, shall we?"

Triss observes quietly, her eyes morphing from disgust to intrigue. She slowly places her pointer finger between her lips to cover her expression.

"I'll take your continued silence as a yes. Haha!" Asher robotically chuckles, reeling back with a thousand-yard stare.

Eventually, he exhales and slumps back down, disheartened. After a moment of thought, Asher regains his posture and scratches the back of his head.

“Look,” Asher begins, looking down. “I’m the seventh tutor, right? Everyone else quit?” Triss gives a small shrug. “I mean, I don’t know you or your sisters that well, but I can kind of see why.” She rolls her eyes. “With that said...I can also see why you would be skeptical of me. Still doesn’t justify you calling me a loser the first time we met.”

With an almost thoughtful expression, Triss turns her head down the hallway. Asher shakes his head and sighs.

“I’m not going to force you to do anything. But, I don’t plan on quitting any time soon,” Asher says, standing tall. He places his hand over his heart. “Against my better judgement, I plan to support you and your sisters as best I ca—.”

“So who is it?” Triss interrupts, lowering her finger to reveal a sly grin. Asher freezes.

“What? Who?” Asher stammers, caught completely off guard.

“Don’t play dumb~,” Triss says, her voice smooth and cunning.

“I—Huh?” Asher blurts, becoming increasingly confused. “What are you talking about?”

“All that talk, and I have to spell it out for you? Good grief.” Triss grabs the hem of Asher’s shirt, dragging towards the hallway. He stumbles forward, more worried about Triss stretching his shirt than her strength.

I’m generally good at remembering things. Moreso, I’m good at remembering faces, besides the identical sisters. In a crowd, I can easily pinpoint people I recognize, especially when I’ve known them for so long. Maybe...too well.

In a split second, Asher’s eyes magnetize towards a familiar individual. A surge of nostalgia, guilt, and panic rush through Asher’s body like a bolt of lightning, forcing him to involuntarily snap backwards. After falling over and performing a backward summersault, he accidentally returns back on his feet, profusely blushing.

“O-M-G, I was right~?” Triss says, giddy with excitement.

“Right about...nothing about it...you didn’t...” Asher rambles, short circuiting. He quickly turns away.

“The nerd got into some *drama~!*” Triss gets up close to Asher, adorning a large grin. “Now spill, who is it?”

“D-drama? Me? Nope! Absolutely not, haha!” Asher laughs, slightly hysterical. He tries subtly shimmying away, but Triss continues to trail him.

“It has to be one of the girls down the hall, right?” Triss questions. She looks back and gasps. “One of the school counsel girls?! No way~! I bet I could ask Monette to see if she knows one of them.”

“No please—,” Asher blurts.

“Why so shy? You weren’t earlier,” Triss teases, covering her mouth with one hand. “Man, if you’re this flustered it must have been *really* bad! Ha, maybe the incident with Queenie will make it worse!”

“Shy? Yes! I am shy! I am just...deathly afraid of women. That’s it!” Asher yells, raising his hands and walking backwards from Triss. The morning bell chimes. “What a *fantastic* coincidence. Time for me to head off! Hope to see you at the library...or maybe not. BYE!”

Asher bolts off and outside of Nine Point at a brisk pace. Without a chance to breathe, Triss runs after him with an larger grin.

“Oh come on! Don’t you have class?!” Asher yells through the Euler courtyard.

“You really think I care about class?” Triss rebuttals, not far behind. “Gimme the goss!”

“Just drop it!” Asher pleads.

The chase scene extended to the rest of the campus. They run around the entrance of the gym, Asher tries losing Triss at the large stairs to the auditorium, and both trudge through the uncut grass around the perimeter of the school. This, of course, brought more attention to the two of them.

“You harassed someone, didn’t you?” Triss says. “Ooo, or maybe something worse!”

“What is *wrong* with you?!” Asher asks in dismay. “I thought *I* was bothering *you*! Go back to being disdainful towards me!”

“Nuh-uh~!” Triss giggles.

Running across nearly half the campus, Asher finally reaches his first period class, with Triss still following him.

“Don’t think you got away~. I’ll figure it out eventually,” Triss promises, emanating a sinister undertone.

“How about you *figure out* how to improve your grade!” Asher yells, before slamming the classroom door shut. Out of breath, he wipes the sweat from his forehead. *Never again...*

Huffing and puffing, Asher sinks down into his seat. He crosses his arms and drops his face onto the desk. *I'm so tired. This tutoring thing may actually kill me.*

Asher opens his eyes and looks ahead, only to find his view completely obstructed. He squints. *Okay, that's a skirt...and a leg.* Asher lifts his head up slowly, seeing the repulsed expression of the girl sitting on his desk.

“What are you *doing*?” She asks, in an accusational tone.

“I’m just sitting down,” Asher responds, unperturbed. He narrows his eyes. *Long straight hair, puffy dress, red eyes...chesticles.* “Monette.”

“You struggled on purpose, didn't you?” Monette questions, her eyebrows slightly furrowing.

“We haven't interacted in a while; it's going to take me a second. Be glad I got it right,” Asher answers, resting his cheek on his fist.

“You didn't need to use that tone,” Monette says. She turns away, switching and recrossing her legs.

“You’re one to talk,” Asher mutters, his exhaustion seeping through his words. “Why are you sitting on my desk?”

“Does it matter? It's not like we have assigned seating,” Monette says. She pinches a few strands of her hair and begins to roll them between her fingers.

“Yeah, but this is *my* seat,” Asher mumbles. At that moment, Asher sits up and briefly scans around him. “Where’s your little entourage?”

“Entour—what?” Monette turns back around, down at Asher.

“Oh? I’m surprised the privileged princess doesn't have more of a refined vocabulary,” Asher comments, his expression barely shifting.

“*Princess?*” Monette echoes. Although faint, the recognizable flush appears on her face as she grits her teeth.

“What’s *your* problem?”

Asher’s mouth instinctively opens to retort, but after a second of consideration, he bites his tongue. *Damn...I think I'm still on edge.* His body slumps back down onto the table.

“...Sorry,” Asher mumbles.

“I swear! You—” Monette snaps on impulse, but is caught off guard from Asher’s response.

“You typically have a group surrounding you. I was just...curious,” Asher says, sinking his face deeper into his arms

Monette’s frown quickly fades, but the flush grows faintly. A few seconds of contemplation goes by. Both parties refuse to say anything. Uncomfortable air begins to circulate between the two of them.

“I...” Monette begins softly, attempting to break the silence. “Don’t worry about it.” More silence ensues.

“Could you get off my desk?” Asher grumbles, barely audible with his face in his arms. “Class is about to start.”

“Seriously? What is your obsession with this piece of school property?” Monette mocks, recrossing her legs again. Slowly, Asher lifts his head and rests his chin on his arm.

“But...it’s *my* desk,” Asher quietly whines in a high pitched voice. He darts his eyes up to Monette’s, who leans back with a sharp exhale.

“You’re weird,” Monette mumbles, sliding off the table. Asher shows a faint, tired smile. *I know*. At a sluggish pace, Asher reaches down to grab his textbook.

Suddenly, a loud thud Asher makes him jolt from his table. He quickly whirls his head around, to find Monette

placing a crimson messenger bag on the table beside him. She sits down on the chair, analyzing a lock of hair she spun around her finger.

“...*What?* You got something to say?” Monette accuses. She looks up at Asher and narrows her eyes.

“N-no, I wasn’t going to say anything...yet,” Asher responds, put on the spot. He puts his elbow down on his desk and leans in towards Monette. Asher narrows his eyes back at her. “Why are you sitting next to me?”

“Well, I...” Monette murmurs, also put on the spot. Her flush glows brighter, as if she was caught red-handed. “Do I have to repeat myself? I can sit wherever I want!”

“Yeah, yeah, you can keep telling yourself that,” Asher dismisses, languishly tilting his head back. “You sat in the back of the class ever since school started. I highly doubt you’d change without a rea—”

Unintentionally, Asher leans back in his chair and turns towards the back. There, he makes eye contact with many familiar faces, all with scornful glares.

“Ah,” Asher whispers in realization. “It appears that I have found the *entourage*.”

“I said don’t worry about it,” Monette emphasizes, gritting her teeth.

“Uh, I’m not sure *I’m* the one worrying,” Asher says, slightly grinning.

“Just...pay attention. Class is about to start,” Monette says, defeated. Asher slowly turns back around, taking a few double-takes to see if they are still looking at him.

“You got it, echo,” Asher teases.

“What did you just call me?” Monette asks, trying not to be offended too loudly.

“Nothing,” Asher mutters.

Period one was proceeding as normal, with Asher returning to his normal behavior. The teacher would provide new material, Asher would raise his hand to ask or answer questions, and the teacher would continue their lesson. Answering another question, Asher sits back down.

Okay, what the heck is her problem? Although Asher tries to focus, he can’t help but take subtle glances beside him.

Twiddling with her fingers, lightly pulling at her hair, and shaking her leg, Monette has progressively gotten more restless throughout class. Additionally, she frequently turns over to Asher with her mouth open, then immediately looks away. She eventually darts her eyes around the room before repeating the cycle.

Normally, I really wouldn’t care. But...I can feel the judgement creeping down my spine. She looks more red than when we first met! I haven’t done anything!

“Hey,” Asher quietly says, leaning towards Monette while staring at the board. “You good? It seems like something’s bothering—.”

“I’m fine!” Monettes yelps.

“Alright, cool, sheesh,” Asher responds, leaning back. Waiting only a few seconds, Monette returns to her torturous spiral. She scrounges through her messenger bag, pulling out a clipboard with a flimsy piece of paper attached to it.

“S-so...um...” Monette murmurs.

“Seriously, *what?*” Asher demands. He takes a quick peek behind him before looking at Monette. “I’m getting funny looks right now and you *clearly* need to say something to me. It would be a lot easier if you—.”

“Could you just *stop!*” Monette snaps, attempting to control her breathing.

“Stop what? You stop!” Asher responds, slightly frustrated. “Also, *you* keep your voice down. The whole idea is to not cause confusion.”

“Shhhh!” Voices from the back resonate together.

“You *shh!*” Asher retorts, turning around. “I’m not talking that loud!”

“Stop bothering her,” one person says. *Oh my god.*

“Wait, wasn’t he the one that pissed his pants?” another snickers. *Oh my god!*

“See? Look where your hesitation has gotten me?” Asher complains. “It was easier for you to argue with me before, what changed?”

“Hey, it’s not my fault you’re difficult!” Monette rebuttals.

“*Difficult?* You’re the one who is being difficult here! I’m trying to pay attention but my focus keeps diverging due to your antics,” Asher says.

“Then could you give me a second?” Monette asks. “It’s difficult for me to say...what I need to say, okay?”

“W-what? I find that very hard to believe. Aren’t you the freaking student president of *Euler?*” Asher questions.

“You live and breathe public speeches. You do the whole pep rallies...or whatever. Why are you getting stage fright *now?*”

“Because...shut up!” Monette blurts. “So what if I’m the president?”

“I’d assume the skills of being the president would carry over to conversing with normies,” Asher says. “Unless, you are self conscious about your test score.”

“What did I say about bringing that up?! Are you crazy?” Monette shrills. “Seriously, I’ll fire you the second you bring that up again!”

“Well you seem to be confident throwing that threat around,” Asher mocks. “If you wanted me fired I’d already be gone. Besides, aren’t you a ‘person of your word’? I bet you’re all talk.”

“All talk?” Monette snaps. “Don’t come crying to me when you receive a notice from the dean calling for your resignation.”

“Oh la-di-da, all talk,” Asher continues. “How about we just ask the dean and see what they—.” Suddenly, the intercom sharply rings.

“Asher Verne,” the muffled voice echoes.

“...Huh?” Asher murmurs.

“Asher Verne,” the muffled voice repeats, “please report to the dean’s office.” *That did NOT just happen?*

“*Ooo*, he’s in trouble,” another sneers. In sheer awe, Asher clasps hands and drags them across his face. Solemnly, he stands up and gathers his belongings. Unexpectedly, Asher sees a hand raised right next to him.

“Teacher!” Monette yells, possibly louder than she intended. “As the representative of this school, please allow me to escort Asher to the dean’s office!” A collective gasp rushed past Asher like a gust of wind.

“You wouldn’t...” Asher trails off, staring at the wavering grin on Monette’s face. *Why? Just...why?*

Chapter 8: High Roller’s Table

With class in session, the whole school becomes desolate. Apart from the janitors and faculty members, not a single soul is in sight. The silence only amplifies the thickness in the air.

Keeping their distance, Asher and Monette treaded slowly, side-by-side. Asher looks up, grimacing as he rubs the back of his neck.

On the other hand, Monette stares down at the clipboard she grabbed out of her bag. Her eyes dart across the handwritten words again and again, as if rehearsing for a huge audition. She peaks over to Asher, then returns to scanning her clipboard.

“So...now what?” Asher asks, attempting to break the silence. “Are we going to walk here quietly or are you going to—.”

“Shh!” Monette shushes.

“What are you shushing me for?” Asher retorts, looking down at Monette. “You made that whole display, and now we’re stuck here together, alone. Isn’t this the perfect

opportunity to say what you ‘need’ to say? Wasn't this the whole point?”

“Please...” Monette mumbles, clenching her clipboard harder. “Stop talking...before I change my mind.”

“What are you even—” Asher responds, but immediately cuts himself off. Sighing reluctantly, he looks away from Monette. “Sure bud...”

Both continued to walk silently. Eventually, it was only a matter of time for the awkwardness seeped back in. Asher looks away, now scratching the back of his neck. They exit the building, and start walking across the courtyard.

“C-could, you...” Asher hesitates, his voice softer. “Could you be honest with me; am I...getting fired?”

Monette stumbles, as if tripping over Asher’s words. With some hair landing on her fingers, Monette slowly drops the clipboard to side and begins rolling the hair between her fingers.

“Ah. Okay,” Asher mumbles. He dryly chuckles. “I don’t know why I asked.”

“Honestly,” Monette says, filled with familiar pompousness. “You’re definitely some kind of desperate to be worried about this dumb tutoring job. If you read the fine print,

you’d know all positions at Euler undergo a monthly evaluation.” She doesn’t lift her gaze from the floor.

“Wait, monthly? I haven’t tutored for a month,” Asher questions.

“Well...it happens to be the end of August. Who knows, now could you stop whining?” Monette answers. While lifting the clipboard back to her waist, she takes a quick glance at Asher. He quietly sighs, before planting his hands into his pockets.

For the remainder of the walk, neither acknowledged each other. After trekking across half of campus, they arrive at a large, old, brick building.

Stepping and walking upstairs, Asher and Monette enter a quaint lounge area, big enough to fit six people. Then, just before opening the large glass door to the dean’s office, Monette lifts her hand in front of Asher.

“Wait here. I need to talk to something with Orphelia first,” Monette says, placing her hand back down onto her clipboard.

“Orphelia? First name basis with the dean?” Asher asks.

“...Wait here,” Monette repeats, slightly narrowing her eyes. With a quiet puff, she wraps her hair behind her ear and turns around.

“Hey, that was a genuine—” Asher calls, before being cut off by the closing of the office door, “question...”

A few seconds go by, with Asher standing motionless. *Uh...huh...this feels weird.* He throws himself onto the nearest seat.

Now that I think about it, I haven't had a chance to relax. Is tutoring normally this taxing? Asher slowly sinks deeper into the thin office chair, arms sliding down the railing as if it were a soft, comfy couch. His eyes wander with a weary haze, entranced by the wooden ceiling. *Why am I doing this?*

Many minutes go by, with the sense of draining nothing seeps into the psyche of Asher. *She's probably lying, isn't she? I bet Monette just wanted me to shut up...right? Crap, I need to do something before I start spiralling.*

Jumping from his seat, Asher begins jogging around the building. From room to room, he starts to collect miscellaneous supplies. Pen, markers, poster paper, scissors, and a whole assortment of tools.

Without wasting any time, Asher returns back to his chair and begins to cobble something together. His eyes glue to his hands with extreme accuracy, analyzing every line, cut, and staple.

After another sequence of time, Asher glances back up at the office door. No sound. No movement. He sighs and shakes his head, about to return to his craft until something catches his attention.

“...Interesting,” Asher murmurs, rolling his project up and placing it on his chair. In addition to the office door, across from Asher was a frame filled with pinned up pictures and papers. He stands up to take a closer look.

“Showcasing the prowess and rigor of our esteemed scholastic establishment,” Asher mumbles, reading a laminated news article, “Vince Knox is, once again, setting the standard. Being the second student in Euler history to be awarded first place in the Centurion Exams, his and Percy Verne's achievements...”

Scratching the back of his neck, Asher quickly darts his eyes across the rest of the panel.

“...Saying farewell to many of our beloved and graduating student body members, Euler is now welcoming our

64th student president: Monette Aurea,” Asher reads, his attention caught by the same shade of white. “With a record of 82% student turnout rate, we can finally conclude the exciting close competition.”

Huh, didn't the year just start? How was there already a vote? Oh, maybe Euler hosts it at the end of each school year...that makes sense. Asher lets out a dry chuckle. *Like I would have time to participate if I knew...Heheh.*

Asher continued to skim, quietly reading every excerpt. *I must be living under a rock. Is she seriously this popular? Monette is practically in every other photo, last year's photos. Must be nice...*

Asher's gaze begins to slowly wander off. He quickly shakes his head, snapping out of his trance. *On the bright side, I can at least tell that she's Monette. Unless...could she be Triss? Nah, she doesn't seem the type to clean a beach. Alright, I'm pretty impressed with myself.*

Asher squints his eyes, placing hand on his chin. *Are those bags under here eyes?*

Suddenly, Asher hears a faint rattle from the office door. He jumps back.

“Geez,” Asher says, startled. He closes his eyes and starts rubbing the back of his neck. “Took you long enough. Are you sure *you* aren't the getting eval—”

Without warning, the sounds of forceful steps resonated behind Asher. He barely had time to react, only registering a glimpse once Asher turned around.

The white hair draped over her eyes like a thick curtain, accentuating the fangs popping out from the small, clenched frown. Leaning forward, clenched fists, and long, drawn out breath was all Asher could notice before she turned the corner. *What the heck happened? I've seen Monette flustered before, but she seemed pretty mad. She is definitely mad at me. Should I go after her?*

Asher quickly turns his head between the office door and the exit, getting antsy at his own indecisiveness. Eventually, he peeks inside the office.

“Excuse me,” Asher calls quietly.

“My apologies for the wait,” the dean says with a tired expression. She straightens a stack of papers before setting it aside. “You can come in.”

Timidly, Asher slowly closes the door behind him. He stands up straight and leans against the door like a toddler caught stealing a cookie.

“Monette has already informed you, correct?” the dean asks.

“...I think so.” Asher takes quick glances behind himself, then points at the door with his thumb. “Uh...is everything alright? Was that related to me?” the dean shakes her head.

“You don’t need to worry about it.” the dean starts rustling through a nearby cabinet and pulls out a small, beige folder. “I’m sure you know how she is by now.”

“Um...if you say so,” Asher says. He begins to take a step forward, but nervously retracts back. With a blank, innocent expression, Asher starts fidgeting in place. At the pace the dean was flipping through the folder and writing down notes, Asher started tapping his foot. “Are you sure I didn’t do anything...uh, miss?” the dean hums.

“Most likely.” Asher’s heart immediately drops, his face goes completely pale. the dean laughs heartily. “You have no need to worry! Please, have a seat.”

Like a cornered animal, Asher fearfully steps forward and retracts, before musters the courage to sit down. Twiddling his thumbs, he glues his eyes to the floor.

“Are you feeling alright?” the dean asks, making Asher jolt.

“Ah, right, yeah,” Asher’s voice wavers as he adjusts himself in his seat.

“Uh huh, quite interesting,” the dean says. “I was told you were someone of many words, yes?”

“Yeah,” Asher mumbles, still fidgeting profusely.

Enough time passes that the uneasiness begins to settle in. Asher continues to clench and unclench his hands, with the dean observing him the entire time. She adjusts and places a few files in front of her.

“I don’t want to use up too much, so I’ll make this quick,” the dean says. “You are—”

“I KNOW!” Asher yells, sending the dean back into her seat. Looking back up, Asher blushes from embarrassment and starts coughing. “Sorry. But...I know already.”

Taking a deep breath, Asher begins scratching his arm while continuing to have difficulty making eye contact.

“I just...it really sucks losing this opportunity again,” Asher says, with a slight pit in his throat. “I get it, I understand I can be insufferable sometimes. I can’t even blame her...or them. The only reason why I would be called here today is to...it hasn’t even been a month and I...ruined everything.”

“Hmm?” the dean responds.

“I’m like a curse, or I am cursed. I can’t do anything right, and I eventually...just push everyone away. In hindsight, I definitely said some things I shouldn’t have...couldn’t keep my stupid mouth shut.” Asher rambles quietly.

“Huh?” the dean responds again.

“Oh, my apologies,” Asher says, rubbing one of his tear duct. He chuckles. “Dang, I am probably too dense to know what I did wrong. But...I hope the letter is given to someone who deserves it.” A brief silence fills the room.

“What? What are you talking about?” the dean asks, stunned and completely confused. The response kickstarts Asher’s brain as he left with a completely blank expression. “?”

She...wasn't lying to me? Then why did she look so mad at me earlier?!

“Ah, I see,” the dean says with a smile on her face. “I understand where you are coming from. Surprisingly, no. There is no need to worry.”

“Really?” Asher asks, in disbelief. “So this is just a routine evaluation?”

“Oh,” the dean thinks. “Not technically, since not enough time has passed to see the sisters’ progress. But we can start with a